The Road Beyond Hazelwood

CHAPTER ONE

River Rope

When seven boys came after Philip, he did not look for the biggest one. He looked for the way out.

The way out was the dock, which was not a good way out at all.

He had been trying to get home before the others caught up. Hazelwood's school sat above the river road, and the quickest route to his father's shop ran past the landing. Philip had taken it because it was quick. The boys had taken it because they knew he would.

He had tried the upper lane first. It passed the baker's yard and added almost ten minutes, but the baker's dog usually slept beside the oven door and the dog liked Philip. That afternoon the lane had been blocked by a cart unloading sacks. Philip had gone back rather than squeeze between the wheels and the wall, because he did not want to explain a torn sleeve to Father. By the time he reached the river road, the boys were already behind him.

They had not always been seven. Sometimes there were three, sometimes two. The number changed, but the rules did not: they chose a place with no teacher, found something he had said or carried, and made him answer for it until he tried to leave. Philip had learned to notice where they stood and how quickly they moved. He had not learned how to make them stop.

At school that day, one of them had taken Philip's slate and held it above his head. Philip had reached for it once, then stopped when the others began to laugh. He had taken it back when the boy got bored. It seemed that the boys had

remembered the pause more clearly than Philip had remembered the slate.

He heard their shoes on the boards behind him and kept walking. The river moved alongside the dock, brown-green under the late light. It was broad enough that the opposite bank looked like another country, though it was mostly willow trees and a stretch of pasture. A barge was tied below the far end, its ropes creaking whenever the current pulled.

"Philip."

He stopped. There was no point pretending not to hear. The first boy stood between him and the road. The others spread out behind, making a fence of shoulders and smirks. One of them still had a piece of chalk in his hair from school. Philip had noticed it earlier and decided not to tell him. That had seemed like the sort of small kindness a person might appreciate. It had not.

"You're in a hurry," said the first boy.

"I'm expected at the shop."

"Then you'd better go."

He stepped aside. Philip moved toward the gap. A hand caught the back of his coat.

They shoved him against the rail. His shoulder struck the wood, and a burst of pain ran down his arm. Someone laughed. Philip twisted, trying to wrench free without swinging his fists. A blow caught his cheek. His eyes watered. Another struck his ribs, and the air left him in a small, humiliating sound.

There were too many of them, and they had arranged themselves so that every direction led to one of their hands. Philip tried once to push through. He was met with a shoulder and a boot against his shin. The dock boards scraped his palms.

"Stand up," one of them said, as if Philip had chosen to sit down.

He got one knee under him. They hauled him upright. For a moment he saw the landing clearly: the mooring post, the

coil of rope beside it, the dark water between the dock and the bank. Then a pair of hands struck his back.

The river closed over his head.

It was colder than he expected. Cold made the world simple. There was the pressure in his ears, the drag of his coat, the bright confusion of bubbles. He kicked for the surface and came up choking. The dock rose beside him, its boards slick and high. He reached for the edge and missed.

Above him, the boys were still there. Their faces had changed. They looked smaller now, though they had not moved. One leaned over the rail, then drew back when Philip's hand slapped against the boards.

He tried again. His fingers found the edge. A foot came down on his knuckles.

Philip let go before the boy could stamp on them a second time. He swallowed river water and drifted away from the dock, coughing. The current carried him along the bank. It was not fast, but it was strong enough to make standing seem like a distant possibility.

He could not shout. He could barely breathe.

For a moment he kicked without choosing a direction. The water pressed his coat against him and turned the light above into a wavering patch. He forced his arms to move. One stroke, then another. He reached the surface, gulped air, and tried to keep his face above it. The dock ran past him as the current carried him along the pilings.

Then he saw a rope.

It ran from a low iron ring set into the bank, passed along the muddy edge, and trailed into the water near the landing. The current lifted its loose length and laid it down again. Philip caught it with both hands. It slipped through his fingers, rough and swollen with water.

He did not pull at once. The rope might be loose. It might be tied to something that would come away. He pressed his heels against the bank and gave the line a short, careful tug.

The iron ring held.

Philip drew himself along the rope, hand over hand, keeping his shoulder close to the bank. Mud slid under his boots. The current pushed at his legs, and the rope bit into his palms, but it led toward the shallows. At last his knee struck gravel. He crawled up until the river was behind him and his breath had become his own again.

For several seconds he stayed on his hands and knees, coughing into the grass.

The boys had gone. So had his school satchel. A book lay open in the shallows, its pages turning slowly as the river read them in a language Philip did not know. He waded in to collect it, then found the satchel downstream, where it had caught against a willow root. The leather was soaked. One strap had torn.

His cheek throbbed, his ribs hurt when he breathed, and his hand was already swelling where the foot had come down. He could have gone home by the road. Instead, he walked beside the river for a while, letting the wet sleeve of his coat hang away from his skin.

By the time he reached the square, the light had begun to slant across the shopfronts. His father's shop stood near the center, with flour in the front window and a hand-painted board above the door. The board said GENERAL GOODS, though the shop sold so many different things that people often came in asking for something it did not have and left with three things they had not meant to buy.

The bell above the door gave a tired jingle when Philip entered.

His father looked up from a ledger. His gaze went first to Philip's wet clothes, then to his face, then to the soaked satchel in his hand.

"You're late."

"Yes."

"What happened?"

Philip put the satchel on the counter. Water ran from its bottom in a thin line. "They threw me in the river."

His father closed the ledger. The sound was small, but the shop seemed to hear it. “Who?”

“The boys from school.”

“All of them?”

“There were seven.”

His father came around the counter. He reached toward Philip’s cheek, and Philip leaned away before he could stop himself. His father’s hand paused in the air. Then he lowered it.

“Did you hit one of them?”

“No.”

“Why not?”

Philip looked at him. “Because there were seven.”

“You can’t let them do this to you.”

“I didn’t let them.”

His father’s jaw tightened. “Next time, you fight back.”

“You know I’m not a fighter.”

“You can learn.”

“How?”

His father opened his mouth, then shut it. For a moment he looked more tired than angry. The distinction did not help Philip much.

“You start by standing your ground,” he said.

“I did. They pushed me into the river.”

“Then you get back up.”

Philip felt his bruised ribs with one careful breath. “I got out.”

“That isn’t what I mean.”

“I know.”

The words came out sharper than he intended. His father’s expression changed, not enough to name, but enough for Philip to see that he had landed a blow of his own. It was a small one. Philip had not meant to throw it.

His father glanced down at the wet satchel. “Go upstairs and change. Then bring your coat down. I’ll see if Mrs. Vale has anything to mend that strap.”

"It doesn't need mending."

"It will when your books fall into the street."

That, at least, was true. His father took a clean cloth from the shelf and set it on the counter beside him.

"For your cheek," he said.

Philip pressed it to his face. The cloth smelled faintly of soap and dried lavender. "Thank you."

His father nodded, as if there were more to say and he had misplaced it. Philip went up the narrow stairs to the rooms above the shop. He peeled off his coat and shirt, wincing as the cloth dragged across his ribs. The bruises were beginning to show: purple along his side, red at his shoulder. He washed the river mud from his hands. The skin over his knuckles was split, though he had not punched anyone.

He stood at the basin longer than he needed to. He could hear the shop below: the scrape of a crate, his father's voice answering a customer, the bell at the door. Ordinary sounds. The kind that had existed before the river and would continue after it. Philip found comfort in that. A shop was a place where things had labels and prices, and if a person was patient, the numbers usually came out right.

When he returned, the afternoon light lay in long bands across the shop shelves. His father was tying a parcel for a farmer. Philip took over the ledger, drying the damp cover with a cloth before he opened it. He added the day's figures twice. They matched the first time, which was reassuring. The second time, too, which was unnecessary but satisfying.

A shepherd came in for lamp oil while Philip was totaling the flour account. He had dust on his boots and a burr caught in the wool at his cuff. He spoke to Father in a low voice. Philip kept his eyes on the ledger, though he heard the pause before the man said giant, and the way his father stopped counting coins.

The shepherd left with his oil. Philip finished the column and looked up.

"Is it true?"

His father glanced over. "What?"

"That something came down from the mountain."

His father considered the question. He did not answer quickly, which meant he was choosing his words or deciding how many of them Philip was allowed to have.

"A shepherd saw a giant on the northern track," he said. "It left the mountain and went into the forest."

"How large?"

"Large enough that the shepherd did not wait to measure it."

Philip had never seen a giant. He had seen drawings of them in old books: long arms, blunt faces, clothes made from whole curtains, as if giants had never met a tailor willing to discuss the matter. The drawings made them seem almost ordinary. A person could grow accustomed to anything on paper.

"Will it come here?"

"It's in the forest now."

"That isn't an answer."

His father rested one hand on the window frame. "No. I don't know if it will come here."

It was not the answer Philip wanted, but it was at least an answer. The forest began beyond the northern farms, behind the ridge. It was a place on the shop map, full of green marks and old roads. Philip had no reason to go there. People sometimes did, for hunting or timber or foolishness, but most came back with mud on their boots and less to say than they had expected.

He could stay in Hazelwood. He could help with the shop. The river and the forest could keep their own troubles.

Outside the window, the river kept moving toward the south. Philip returned to the ledger. There was still a column to finish, and columns, unlike rivers and giants, generally went where the numbers told them.

CHAPTER TWO

The Arrow Seller

The afternoon belonged to Philip, more or less.

Unkati was the day Father let him run the shop. Father still came through from the storeroom when a delivery arrived or a customer asked for a price Philip had never seen in the ledger, but the counter was Philip's, as were the sums, the stock book, and the small decisions that made a shop run smoothly. It was not a kingdom. It was better than a kingdom, because the shelves had labels.

Philip had just finished adding the flour account for the second time when the bell above the door jingled.

The man who entered wore the sort of coat people turned to look at and then pretended they had not. It was made from a beast's hide, broad across the shoulders and dark at the edges, with a pair of folded wings hanging nearly to his boots. The creature's narrow head had been worked into the hood. Its hooked beak rested beside the man's ear, and the hide smelled faintly of rain, leather, and old smoke.

The man himself was lean and travel-worn. His boots had holes at the seams. His fair hair, streaked with mud, fell past his shoulders. A bow rode across his back, and a quiver sat high enough to clear the long tails of his coat.

"Do you sell arrows?" he asked.

Philip knew the voice. He had heard it at the square, in stories told by people who had never been within ten miles of the places they described. This was Aro Silvet, a famous hunter and archer south of the borderlands—or, depending on who was telling the story, the finest beast tracker, wilderness

guide, and general person to have survived a remarkable number of things.

Philip stood too quickly and knocked his knee against the counter. "Yes, sir. We have arrows. They're just over here."

"Aro," the man said. "Sir makes me sound like I'm about to inspect the shelves."

Philip reached beneath the counter for the arrow box. "Aro, then."

He placed it on the wood and lifted the lid. The arrows inside were slender and pale, each with a dark green binding below the fletching. An elf had traded them at the shop the previous season. Philip had checked every shaft before putting them away. None was bent. The points were clean and narrow, and the feathers had been cut to the same length with the kind of care that made a person suspect the maker had measured them twice and then measured the measuring tool.

Aro picked one up without touching the point. He rolled the shaft between his fingers, tested the balance, and ran his thumb along the binding.

"What would you check first?" he asked Philip.

Philip leaned across the counter. "Whether the shaft is straight."

"And after that?"

"The fletching. If one side is heavier, it could turn."

Aro nodded. He sighted along the shaft, then spun it lightly between two fingers. The arrow turned without wobbling. "You know the parts."

"I sell them."

"That is how most people learn. They think a bow does the work and the arrow merely goes along. An arrow has opinions."

Philip studied the green binding. "Can you tell what kind of wood it is?"

"Not without cutting it open. But I can tell it has been dried properly." Aro tapped the shaft near its center. "That

matters when the weather changes. The maker knew the wood would swell, and left room for it."

Philip had thought of arrows as things that were either straight or bent, sharp or dull. Aro seemed to see the decisions that had gone into each one. Philip wondered what a person would have to learn to notice all of them.

"Elven work?"

"That's what the seller said."

"And what did you say?"

"I asked him to show me the other arrows he had."

Aro smiled. "Good answer."

Philip felt the back of his neck warm. "They're the finest arrows in Hazelwood."

"I believe you." Aro sighted along the shaft, though it was not made for sighting. "Whoever made these knew what the wood would do after it left the bow. That matters more than a polished point."

Philip glanced at the box. He had noticed the even shafts and the clean bindings, but had not considered what they would do in flight. He wanted to ask. Aro was already putting the arrow back.

"How many?"

"All of them, if you'll sell them."

Philip blinked. "There are twelve."

"I can count."

The remark was dry, not unkind. Philip closed the lid halfway, then opened it again. A customer might ask for all twelve and buy two. That happened often. People liked to make a decision sound larger before they knew its price.

"They're not cheap," Philip said.

"Good." Aro leaned on the counter. "Cheap arrows have a habit of being cheap at the important end."

Philip named the price. He had added a little for the elven work and a little more because the arrows were rare. He had not added enough to be ashamed of it. Aro paid without bargaining, and Philip counted the coins once, then a second

time because he did not want to be the sort of shopkeeper who trusted a stranger's pile of money more than his own arithmetic.

"You're careful," Aro said.

"I'm counting."

"That's one way to be careful."

Philip began wrapping the arrows in brown paper. He kept their points turned away from the edge of the counter. "What do you need twelve for?"

"I don't know yet."

Philip looked up.

Aro's smile had disappeared. "The road has been giving me reasons to prepare."

Before Philip could ask what that meant, Father came in from the storeroom, wiping his hands on a cloth. His attention went first to the hide coat, then to the man wearing it.

"Aro Silvet," he said. "I wondered when you'd come through again."

"I was beginning to think you'd stopped keeping arrows."

"We keep what people need."

"That must be why Philip found these." Aro tapped the wrapped bundle. "He has a gift for selling."

Father's face softened with pride. "He means to stay with the shop. The wild places don't much appeal to him."

"A wise preference," Aro said. "A wild place rarely has a roof when it rains."

"You're wearing one," Philip said before he could stop himself.

Aro looked down at the hide. "This is a roof with poor manners."

Father gave a brief laugh. Philip had never heard him laugh with a customer before. It made the moment feel less like a sale and more like the beginning of a story that had been waiting in the back room.

Aro looked at Philip again. "You look like a warrior."

Philip's fingers tightened around the paper. He thought of the dock and the river and the seven boys standing above him. "I don't."

"Most people don't, until they've had to be one."

"That isn't always something to hope for," Father said.

Aro studied him. "Your son's name is Philip?"

"Yes."

Something shifted in Aro's expression. It was brief, but the shop was quiet enough for Philip to see it. The hunter glanced at the bundle, at the counter, and finally at the boy.

"I had a friend named Philip," he said. "He was a brave man."

The word brave settled over Philip more heavily than it should have. He imagined it was a word adults used when there was nothing simpler to say.

"What happened to him?"

Aro folded his hands on the counter. "An Alcrog swallowed him."

"Did he know it was coming?"

"He knew it was there. We were tracking it through a ravine. It came down from the ledge above us." Aro paused, choosing a place to set the memory. "The first warning was a shadow. We both saw it. I told him to run for the rocks. He went the other way, because I was still in the open."

"Was that brave?"

Aro looked at him for a moment. "Yes."

"Would it have been better if you had run?"

"Possibly."

Philip looked at Father. His father had gone still beside the shelves. Aro's answer seemed to surprise him as much as it surprised Philip.

"I don't tell the story because it was a good plan," Aro continued. "I tell it because he was my friend, and he did what he could with the time he had."

Philip felt his eyes move to the hide coat. The creature's beak rested beside Aro's ear. Beneath it, the great wings swept

down behind him, nearly brushing the floor. The hide had been scraped and stitched, but the shape of the beast remained. It was not a costume. It was what was left after the hunter had finished with the living thing.

"It swallowed him?" Philip asked.

"Whole."

"And he got out?"

Aro's eyes held his. "He killed it from the inside. Cut its heart out."

Father's cloth stopped moving in his hands.

"How?" Philip asked.

"With a blade. He had one with him." Aro looked down at his own hands. "The Alcrog took flight. It was too late to stop it before it rose. When it fell, Philip survived the impact. He had done the impossible part. I thought I could save him after."

He paused. No one in the shop moved. Even the bell above the door seemed to have remembered its manners.

"But he was badly wounded," Aro continued. "He bled out before I could get him to shelter."

Philip looked at the wrapped arrows. He had expected a story about a hero and a monster, with the kind of ending people told when they wanted children to sleep without imagining teeth. Instead, Aro had described a man who won and died anyway.

"I'm sorry," Philip said.

Aro nodded. For the first time since he had entered, he seemed uncertain what to do with his hands. "He was my friend. He was also the sort who would have been irritated if I made too much of it."

"Would he have wanted you to wear the hide?" Philip asked.

Father's eyes flicked toward him. Aro did not seem offended. He looked at the coat's winged shoulders, the creature's beak, and the worn stitching along the hem.

"He would have asked whether it was warm," Aro said. "And then he would have told me I'd put it on backward."

The answer made Philip smile, though Aro did not. His gaze had turned distant, fixed on something beyond the shop wall.

Father stepped closer to the counter. Aro's expression changed. "Not here," he said.

Father answered in Elvish.

Philip knew a handful of words, mostly the sort travelers used when they wanted to buy something or complain about the price. His father's speech was too quick for him. Aro replied just as quietly. They spoke with the ease of people who had once said far more to each other than the present conversation required.

Philip caught a word that sounded like road. Then another that might have meant broken. His father asked a question. Aro shook his head.

They had not moved far from the counter. That made the quiet feel deliberate. Philip busied himself with the wrapping paper, though the bundle was already tied.

When Father switched back to the common tongue, his voice was level. "You'll go on to Malcore?"

"I'll reach the Road Office before the week is out. They need to hear what I saw."

"I'll bring my family south."

Philip looked up. His father was watching Aro, not him.

"You were planning to come later," Aro said.

"Plans change."

"They usually do when roads are involved."

Father asked one more question in Elvish. Aro replied, and this time he looked directly at Philip. Whatever he had said, it was not meant for the boy.

Aro picked up the arrows. "Thank you for the sale, Philip."

"You're welcome."

"Keep your eyes open on the road."

Father's mouth tightened slightly. "He knows how to watch where he's going."

Aro did not argue. He drew the hide around his shoulders and pushed the door open. The afternoon air stirred the arrow feathers through the paper. The bell gave its tired jingle as he left.

Philip watched the coat's wings disappear past the window.

"What did you say to him?" he asked.

Father gathered the coins and returned them to the till. "We talked about the north road."

"In Elvish?"

"It's a useful language for private conversation."

That was not an explanation. Philip looked at the coins, at the empty space where the arrows had been, and at his father's hands as they closed the till. Father counted the money once. Then, after a pause, he counted it again.

The numbers came out the same both times.

CHAPTER THREE

The Early Trip

By the time Father closed the shop, the light had gone from the square and the windows showed more lamplight than sky.

Philip carried the ledger upstairs. His father brought the day's takings and the wrapped arrows' empty place in the stock book. They counted the coins at the kitchen table while a pot of mushroom stew warmed over the stove. The numbers matched. They always did when Philip counted them, though Father still checked.

"Aro said you have a gift for selling," Father said.

"He bought all twelve arrows."

"That's a good sale."

"He knew exactly what he wanted."

"Most customers don't."

Philip aligned the coins by size. "What did he tell you?"

Father set down the ledger. "About what?"

"The north road."

"We spoke about Malcore."

"That's not what you spoke about."

Father looked toward the window, though the road outside had gone dark. "I think we should go to Malcore."

Philip's hand stopped over the coins. "When?"

"Tomorrow. We leave at first light."

The words arrived with the same ordinary calm as a request to bring down another sack of flour. Philip looked at his father, waiting for a smile or some sign that this was a joke. Father merely folded the ledger shut.

"We went last year."

"We did."

"We weren't going to go again for a while."

"Plans change."

Philip glanced at the coins. "What's changed?"

Father drew his chair back and sat. He looked more worn than he had when Aro left, though the day was not yet over. "I think some time away would do us good."

"You said that last year."

"Did I?"

"You said Hazelwood was a little full."

"It can be."

Philip thought of the dock, the bruises, the faces above him. Father knew about the boys. He had not brought it up again. Philip had not, either. The subject sat between them as neatly as a third place setting.

"Is this because of them?"

"It's not only because of them."

"That means it is partly because of them."

"It means we have reasons to go."

His father reached for the coins and began sorting them again. He did that when he wanted a conversation to stop. It was a useful habit in the shop, where most conversations should stop once the customer had paid.

"I like Hazelwood," Philip said. "I like the shop. I don't want to leave just because some boys decided I'm an easy target."

He liked knowing which drawer held the spare weights and which customers needed to be asked twice before they admitted what they were actually looking for. He liked the steady work of balancing the till, the little satisfaction of finding a missing measure where someone had set it down, and the way Father trusted him with the keys when a delivery came after dark. The shop was not a small life. It was a life he understood.

"They don't decide what you are."

"Then why did you tell me to fight them?"

Father's fingers went still against the table.

"Because I don't want you hurt."

"It didn't stop them."

"I know."

The answer was so quiet that Philip looked up. His father's mouth was set, but the anger had gone from it. For a moment he seemed to have run out of instructions.

"I don't want to be a fighter," Philip said. "I want to run the shop."

"You can do that."

"You keep telling me I need to be strong."

"You do."

"For what?"

His father did not answer. The stew simmered on the stove. From the front room came the soft tick of the clock above the shop stairs. Each sound gave the silence another place to settle.

Philip looked down at the coins. The largest was a little worn around its edge. He turned it until the stamped crown caught the lamplight.

"You never tell me what you mean," he said.

Father rested his hands on the table. "Sometimes I don't know how to say it without making it sound like an order."

"You could try saying it before it turns into one."

His father took that in without looking away. Philip could not tell whether he agreed. The answer might have been hidden in the same place as the one about the giant.

"Strength isn't only fighting," Father said at last.

"You said I should hit them."

"I said you should stand your ground."

"Those sounded like the same thing."

"They aren't."

Philip waited for more. Father looked down at the ledger again. No more came.

They ate the stew while it was still warm. Philip asked how many days the trip would take. "A few," Father said. "The wagon should make it easier than walking, if the road holds

and the horses keep their pace." They would buy stock, speak to the suppliers, and come home. It was the familiar trip: sacks, crates, lists, and a room above an inn where the floorboards complained whenever someone crossed them.

"And the giant?" Philip asked.

"We'll hear more in Malcore."

"From Aro?"

"From people who know the roads."

That answer sounded sensible and incomplete. Philip was beginning to understand that the two qualities often traveled together.

After supper, Father went to the storeroom and returned with a small wooden box. He carried it in both hands, though it was no bigger than a loaf of bread. Its dark surface had been polished smooth by years of handling. The hinges were narrow and precise. A lock sat in the front, worked from pieces of metal that fitted together in a pattern Philip could not follow.

He had been gone long enough for Philip to wash the bowls and stack them beside the sink. When Father returned, the box rested across both his palms as carefully as if it might wake.

"This is dwarven," Philip said.

"The box is."

"What's inside?"

"Something I was given when I left the Slayers."

Philip touched one of the hinges. "You never said you had it."

"I didn't think it was time."

"And now it is?"

Father set the box on the table. "I want you to have it."

Philip looked from the lock to his father. "Why?"

"Because I think it's time you had it."

"That isn't an answer."

Father's eyes narrowed a little. The words had sounded familiar because they were. Philip had used them earlier, when

Father told him the giant was in the forest but could not say if it would come to Hazelwood.

Philip drew a finger along the box's smooth lid. "Does it have anything to do with the giant?"

"Not directly."

"Does that mean it has something to do with the road?"

Father looked at him for a long moment. "It has to do with my old work."

"The Slayers."

"Yes."

"You never tell me anything about them."

"There isn't much that would help you."

"You can't know that without telling me."

Father's hand rested beside the box, close to the lock but not touching it. "The Slayers are gone. I don't want you thinking this belongs to them more than it belongs to you."

"I don't even know what it is."

"You will."

"When?"

Father drew the box toward himself and then pushed it back again, a small movement that made the polished wood scrape against the table. "When I can explain it properly."

Philip felt the old frustration rise. "You keep deciding what I'm ready to hear."

"I'm trying to be careful."

"You say that when you don't want to answer."

Father did not deny it. He lifted the box and placed it in his own travel bag, open beside him. He fitted the box between his clothes so it would not slide, then tied the flap twice. A small key appeared in his hand; he checked it, then returned it to the inside pocket of his vest.

Philip watched him. "You're taking it with us."

"Yes."

"And I still won't know why."

"Not yet."

The answer irritated Philip. It also confirmed that the box mattered. He had no way of knowing whether it mattered in a way that would change his life or only because Father had carried it for so long. Adults often kept objects for reasons that were clearer to the object than to anyone else.

After Father went to bed, Philip lay awake listening to the shop settle. He could hear the clock, the wind against the shutters, and his father moving once in the room across the hall. The day had started with a river and ended with a box he was not allowed to open. Between them stood seven boys, a giant in the forest, and a trip that had become urgent without becoming clear.

He packed a change of clothes, two books, his school things, and the twelve coins he had saved. Father added a small purse of household money and reminded him not to spend it on sweets. Philip had never spent household money on sweets. He had spent his own money on sweets, which was different in the way that mattered to Philip and perhaps not in the way it mattered to Father.

He made a list on the back of an old receipt: shirt, socks, book, school slate, pencil, coins. Then he checked the bag against the list and the list against the bag. The first time, he had forgotten the slate. The second time, he had written "slate" twice. The third time was correct, though it did not make the bag any larger.

He stood over the two books for several minutes. One was a history of Malcore's old bridges, which he had already read once. The other was a collection of short accounts from travelers, most of whom had been surprised by weather. He chose the bridge book. If the weather turned out to be surprising, he could look out the window.

He left his lantern burning while he packed. He told himself it was because the room was dim. The room was dim. It was also true that he preferred to see what stood in the corners.

Father secured his travel bag and checked the wagon's harness twice, then laid the route map beside the reins. Philip noticed a second map rolled beneath it, older and more worn. Father tucked that one out of sight when he saw Philip looking.

"Is that the route we're taking?" Philip asked.

"It's an old map."

"That isn't what I asked."

"We'll take the South Road."

Philip waited. Father folded the newer map and put it in his coat. The older one disappeared into the travel bag, beside the box.

At the front door, Philip stopped with his hand on the latch. The rooms above the shop smelled of stew, lamp oil, and the lavender soap from the washbasin. He had never thought of them as a place he might have to miss. Father was already outside, checking the harness again.

Philip looked once toward the dark shelves below the stairs. He closed the front door and checked the bolt. Upstairs, he left the lantern burning. Sleep came late and did not stay.

Before dawn, the horses stamped in the yard, their breath white in the chill. Philip climbed onto the passenger bench with his bag between his boots. Father climbed up beside him and gathered the reins.

"Ready?" he asked.

Philip looked back at the shop windows, dark now, their shelves hidden behind the glass. "No."

His father waited.

Philip settled the bag against his feet. "But I'm coming."

The horses leaned into their traces. The wagon rolled south, out of Hazelwood and onto the old road.

CHAPTER FOUR

Shelf Road

The first hour out of Hazelwood passed beneath a sky the color of old tin.

On ordinary trips, Father let Philip choose which side of the bench he wanted and asked him to read the delivery list aloud. Philip would call the stops while Father watched the road, and they would argue about whether a cracked jar counted as a loss if the buyer had not yet seen it. The arguments had rules. They could be settled by the ledger, or by asking the buyer, or by Father saying that a jar was a jar no matter how philosophical it became.

This morning Father had not brought the delivery list. He had brought two maps and kept one beneath his coat. Philip had seen the corner of the older one when Father folded it. It was drawn on yellowed paper, with a route marked in a darker ink than the surrounding roads.

"You brought two maps," Philip said.

Father glanced down. "One is a backup."

"Which one is the backup?"

"The newer one."

"Then the older one is the one you trust."

"The older one is the one I know."

Philip looked out at the gray road. "Those are different things."

"Sometimes."

Father tucked the corner of the older map farther beneath his coat. Philip did not ask to see it. He had learned that a refusal could begin before a question was finished.

Philip sat beside Father on the wagon bench with his bag between his boots. The horses drew them south at an unhurried trot. The river flashed through gaps in the trees to their right, broad and brown beneath the morning mist. Behind them, the road narrowed until Hazelwood was no more than a low smudge on the northern horizon.

The wagon was the one Father used for the shop's largest orders: two bench seats, a canvas cover rolled above the load, and an iron-banded box beneath the passenger bench for tools. The boards smelled of old grain and damp rope. Philip knew which plank squeaked, which latch needed a lift before it would close, and where Father kept the spare wheel pins. Those details made the wagon feel more like an extension of the shop than a vehicle carrying them away from it.

Father drove without speaking. Philip tried reading, but the wagon had a talent for finding every stone on the road. After the same line jumped beneath his eyes for the fourth time, he closed the book.

"You could have slept another hour," Father said.

"You woke me before dawn."

"You said you were ready."

"I said I was coming."

Father glanced at him, then back at the road. "You did."

The answer left no room for an argument. Philip watched the wheel turn. He had never been bothered by a quiet ride before. Usually he read until the road or the book made him sleepy. Today the silence had too much space in it.

"How long until Malcore?" he asked.

"A few days, if the roads stay passable."

"And if they don't?"

"Then we find another way."

"That sounds like something you say when you don't know."

Father's mouth twitched. "It is."

They stopped once to water the horses at a stream that crossed the road. Philip held the bridle of the nearer animal

while Father checked the wagon wheels and tightened a strap on the load. The animals drank deeply. One lifted its head and blew water across Philip's sleeve.

"That was deliberate," Philip said.

"It was thirsty."

"It could have been thirsty in a less personal direction."

Father rubbed the horse's neck. "You'll have to discuss that with it."

Philip held the reins while Father unfolded the newer map on the wagon seat. The map showed the river, the lower road, and a few bridges. The old South Road was drawn in a thin gray line that vanished and returned as if its maker had been uncertain the road still existed.

"The lower track follows the water," Philip said. "Why does it flood if it's lower?"

"Because the river rises."

"Then it isn't much of a road."

"It works when it's dry."

"That is not the same thing."

Father folded the map. "No. It isn't."

He said it as if Philip had proved something, though neither of them had won an argument.

They moved on. By midmorning, the track had climbed from the riverbank and begun to follow the side of a long ridge. The land fell sharply to the west. On the other side, the ground rose into dark slopes patched with pine. The wagon wheels clicked over old stone set into the road. Here and there, the stones had shifted enough to leave gaps where grass had grown through.

Clouds had gathered over the south since dawn, dark underneath and pale at the edges. Father checked them whenever the road straightened. He said nothing about the weather, but he had begun to drive faster.

"This is the Shelf Road?" Philip asked.

"The old South Road. It runs above the ravine until it meets the lower track."

"Why take the old road?"

"It's shorter."

"By how much?"

"A day, perhaps."

Philip looked over the edge. "That seems like a lot to save."

"The lower track floods when the river rises. The longer way is passable, but it would put us farther from Malcore tonight."

"And we need to get there quickly?"

Father adjusted the reins. "We have reasons to go."

Philip waited. His father did not add any.

The ridge road turned around a shoulder of rock. Ahead, a low stone wall guarded the outer edge. Its upper stones were pale with moss, and a row of old drainage cuts ran beneath them. Water trickled from one cut and crossed the road in a thin silver line. The rain must have fallen sometime in the night. Philip saw where it had carried grit and small leaves from the higher slope and piled them against the road's edge.

There were shallow hollows in the packed dirt between the stones. Rainwater had collected in them, making their outlines hard to see. They were too broad for hoofprints and too irregular for wheels. A larger weight had pressed there, once or several times, though Philip could not tell when. He remembered the shepherd's account of a giant and looked back toward the mountain.

"Are those from it?" he asked.

Father followed his gaze. "Could be."

"You sound certain."

"I'm not."

He drew the horses closer to the inner wall. Philip kept watching the marks until a bend hid them.

"The ditch is blocked," he said.

Father slowed the horses. "Where?"

Philip pointed. "There. And the water's running under the stones instead of through the drain."

His father studied the road. He guided the wagon closer to the inside wall, away from the ravine. The horses shortened their steps.

"We'll take it slowly," he said.

The wagon crept forward. Philip watched the stream of water running through the next drainage cut and tried to judge how much had gone beneath the road instead. The ditch was full of leaves and gravel. A proper road should have carried water away. This one seemed to be storing it for later.

"Could we turn back?" Philip asked.

"Not easily."

"We could go down to the river road."

"That would add a day, and the lower track may be flooded."

"We haven't checked."

Father's eyes stayed on the road. "No."

"Then we don't know it's flooded."

"We also don't know the Shelf Road is unsafe."

Philip looked at the broken drains. "We know it's old."

"Old roads can be sound."

"And unsound ones can look fine until they aren't."

Father glanced at him. For a second Philip thought he might turn the wagon around. Instead, Father eased the reins and kept the horses close to the inner wall. "We'll go one stretch at a time."

It was a practical answer. It was also the kind of answer Philip wished his father had given him about the trip.

Philip looked along the broken wall. A flat length of dark iron had been set into the stone at shoulder height, its surface pitted and marked with narrow grooves. A piece of the stone around it had cracked away. The iron did not look like a sign or a hinge. It looked like part of a much older machine whose purpose had been forgotten when it stopped moving.

"What's that?"

Father glanced at the fitting. His hand tightened on the reins.

"Road iron."

"What does it do?"

"Nothing now."

"Was it part of the drain?"

"No."

Father looked ahead again. The wagon crept forward. Philip tried to read the grooves, but their pattern meant nothing to him. He remembered the box in Father's travel bag, secured beneath the bench. He did not ask whether the fitting had anything to do with it. He had already learned what answers he would get.

The horses passed the first drain. The next was clear. At the third, water slipped through the cut and disappeared beneath the wall. The road dipped slightly where the stone had settled. Philip felt the wagon tilt toward the ravine.

"Father."

"I see it."

"The outside stones—"

The nearer wheel struck a rut. The wagon lurched. One of the horses tossed its head, and the harness creaked.

"Easy," Father said, drawing the reins in.

Something cracked beneath them.

The sound was no louder than a board splitting, but the road shifted under the wagon. Philip looked down at the wheel. A thin line opened between the road and the outer wall, water darkening the seam. The wheel dropped half a handspan.

Philip felt the wagon lean before he saw the ground shift. The outer stones were not merely loose; the whole edge had settled outward. Beneath the road, water had been running where there should have been packed earth. It had washed away the support a little at a time, and the wagon had supplied the final weight.

"Stop!" Philip shouted.

Father pulled hard on the reins. The horses checked their pace. For a heartbeat, the wagon held still, leaning above the

ravine. Philip felt his stomach move as if it had missed the warning.

Then the shoulder collapsed.

Stone and earth gave way beneath the wheels. The wagon tipped toward the open slope. Father released one rein and seized Philip by the back of his coat.

"Out!"

He shoved Philip toward the rock wall. Philip struck the ground on his shoulder and rolled against the inside ledge. The impact knocked the breath out of him. He tried to sit up.

The wagon lurched past.

Father was still on the bench, both hands fighting the reins. The horses pulled sideways, panicked by the broken road. One harness strap snapped. The wagon's outer wheel lifted free of the ground; for a moment the whole load hung at an angle, its crates sliding toward the open side.

Father looked back at Philip. Their eyes met.

The wagon dropped.

The world tipped with it. A horse broke from its traces and galloped along the road, reins whipping behind. The other followed, vanishing around the bend. The wagon struck the ravine slope, bounced once, and rolled out of sight. A burst of wood cracked below. Then came a duller impact and a wash of orange light.

Philip pushed himself onto his knees. The edge of the road was crumbling around him. He could hear a horse somewhere above, snorting and running. He could hear the river far below. He could hear his own breath, fast and shallow, but not his father.

He crawled toward the broken edge.

"Father!"

The slope beneath him shivered. A stone the size of a loaf tumbled down and vanished. Philip reached for the nearest root. His fingers slipped over the dirt.

He tried to stand. His legs did not agree. The sky had turned bright at its center and dark at the edges. He felt blood

run from his hairline to his temple. When he touched it, his hand came away wet.

Below, the wagon burned among the rocks.

Philip heard one more crack, though he could not tell whether it came from the wreckage, the road, or inside his head. He tried to call Father again. The word broke apart before it reached the air.

The ridge tilted. The river rose to meet it.

Then everything went dark.

CHAPTER FIVE

Wreckage

Philip woke because the air hurt to breathe.

He tried to turn over. Pain lit up his shoulder and the side of his head. He stopped, waited for the bright spots behind his eyes to settle, then tried again more carefully. For a few moments he did not know where he was. He knew the smell of smoke, the taste of dirt, and the sound of something burning. The rest of the world had come apart and been put back in the wrong order.

The wagon. The road. Father's hand on his coat.

Philip shut his eyes and tried to hold the pieces still. He could remember the crack under the wheel, the horses lunging, Father shouting. After that, there was only the feeling of falling. He could not remember hitting the ground.

The sky was a pale strip above the ridge. Smoke crossed it in slow, dirty ribbons. Somewhere below, wood cracked in a fire.

Philip pressed his fingers to his hairline. They came away wet with blood. His right hand hurt, but it moved. His left shoulder felt bruised rather than broken. He touched each of his legs in turn, then rolled onto his side and pushed himself upright.

He sat for a while with his back against the stone. When he looked down, the torn cuff of his coat was wet with blood and the front of his shirt was gray with ash. His ears rang. Each time he moved his head, the slope shifted a little. He made himself look at one thing at a time: the rock beside him, the wheel below, the strip of sky above. They stayed where they were.

The wreckage lay below the road, scattered across a shelf of rock and scrub. The wagon had broken apart against the slope. One wheel still turned slowly, though nothing was pulling it. Flames climbed the remains of the cargo bed. Smoke stung Philip's eyes and made his head pulse in time with the fire.

The horses were gone. He could hear hoofbeats fading somewhere up the road.

"Father!"

No answer.

Philip tried to stand and nearly fell. The ground seemed to shift beneath him. He put one hand against a stone until the feeling passed, then followed the wreckage down the slope, picking his steps among broken boards and scattered crates.

He found Father below the wagon's rear axle, half on his side, one arm beneath him. His face was pale beneath the dirt. Blood ran from a cut at his hairline and disappeared into his beard. One leg lay at an angle Philip did not like.

"Father."

Philip knelt. He did not know what to do first. He had read that a person who fell from a height might have broken bones. He had also read that moving them could make matters worse. Books were excellent at explaining the dangers of a situation after somebody else had solved it.

He looked for a wound in Father's chest or stomach and found none he could see through the torn clothes. The leg worried him more. Father's boot pointed outward, and the cloth above it had darkened with blood, but there was no bone showing. Philip did not try to straighten it. He had been told that was how a person made an injury worse, and for once he did not need to ask who had told him.

He leaned close to Father's mouth. A breath warmed his cheek. Philip waited for another. It came, shallow but steady.

"You're alive," he said.

He said it again under his breath. The first time had been for Father. The second was for himself.

Father did not answer.

Philip touched his shoulder. “Can you hear me?”

Nothing.

The wagon creaked. A burning beam shifted and dropped, sending sparks across the stones. Philip flinched away. Father was close enough to the wreckage that the heat had begun to dry the blood on his temple.

Philip tried to pull him by the shoulder. Father’s weight barely moved. His injured leg caught on a rock, and Philip let go at once. The sound he made was more breath than speech. He wiped his face with his sleeve and looked around for something he could use as a litter.

He searched the nearest crates. One had split open and spilled folded cloth into the dirt, but when Philip reached for it, heat drove him back. The side of the cargo bed sagged as the fire took another support. He could hear small things snapping inside the wagon: a jar, perhaps, or a bundle of kindling. He had no way to know how long the wreckage would hold together.

There was nothing unbroken nearby. No blanket. No clean boards. No spare strap. The wagon had been their shelter, their food, and nearly everything they had brought with them. Now it was a fire that kept finding new things to eat.

Philip took hold of the back of Father’s coat instead. He braced one foot against the ground and pulled, inch by inch, keeping Father’s hurt leg as straight as he could. The coat bunched under his hands. The father he was dragging seemed to weigh more than the father who had sat beside him on the wagon bench that morning.

After a few feet, Philip had to stop. His own head swam. He pressed his palm against a cut in the grass and waited until the slope held still again.

“I’m sorry,” he said, though he was not sure which part he meant.

He tried again. A little farther. Then another stop. By the time he reached a patch of bare ground beyond the smoke, his

bruised hand was shaking. He eased Father onto his back, careful not to twist the leg.

The breathing continued.

Philip sat with his hand on Father's sleeve until he felt certain the next breath would come. Then he crawled to the nearby wreckage and called for help. His voice echoed once from the ravine and disappeared. He waited. A horse answered somewhere far up the road, but there was no human voice.

He climbed toward the broken shoulder only as far as the loose ground allowed. The road edge crumbled beneath his boot. He backed away before the dirt could carry him down. From the safer patch below, he could see a length of harness caught on a rock. He tried to reach it with a branch, but the strap slid out of reach and vanished beneath a pile of boards.

When he returned to Father, the fire had shifted. A hot plank leaned toward the grass. Philip found a branch and dragged it away from Father's coat. The wood broke at one end. He dropped it and checked Father's leg again. It had not moved.

There was no water in any of the broken containers. Philip looked toward the river, then at the slope. He could climb down and search for a seep. He might even reach the water. But the ravine was steep, and his head had begun to spin again. If he fell, Father would have no one left to check his breathing.

Philip sat. The choice to stay had to be made again each time there was something else he could try.

Philip watched Father's chest rise and fall. He counted ten breaths, lost count at seven, and began again. On the third try, he made it to ten. Father did not wake. Philip tucked the hem of Father's coat beneath his injured leg to keep it from scraping the stones, then moved his hand away. He did not know whether that helped. It was the only thing he could think of that did not ask the leg to move.

Philip found a strip of cloth torn from his shirt and pressed it against his hairline. The wound was not deep, but

blood had matted his hair and made the world look worse than it was. He tied the cloth around his head, clumsy with one sore hand. When he lowered his arm, his fingers came away red again.

He sat beside Father and tried to count what remained. One torn bag. Two books. The small purse of coins. No food he could find. No water. A coat. A road map torn through the middle. The horses had escaped, but the reins and harness were gone with them. The boxes had broken open on the slope, spilling nails, cloth, and pieces of the shop order into the dust.

The books were not useful as food or shelter, but Philip gathered them anyway. The history of Malcore's bridges had lost its cover. He wiped grit from the pages and tucked it beneath the bag flap. The second book was swollen from water and smoke. He set it aside to dry, although he knew it might not.

He counted again. There was no better answer the second time.

The old road above them was broken where the shoulder had fallen. The lower road was out of sight beyond the ravine. The river made a broad, distant sound. Philip had no idea how far they were from help, only that it was farther than he could carry Father in one attempt.

He could climb back to the road. He might find the horses, or another traveler. He might find a village. Or he might spend the daylight searching while Father lay alone beside the fire.

Philip looked at Father's face. Even unconscious, it seemed stern. The line between his brows had not gone away.

"I'm staying," Philip said.

It was the first decision he had made since the wagon left the road. It did not make him feel brave. It made him feel tired.

The fire settled lower as the afternoon drew on. Philip watched it, keeping one eye on Father and one on the broken slope. When he thought the heat had eased, he searched the

edges of the wreckage for anything that could still be useful. He found the travel bag's torn strap, a few coins, and a tin cup bent nearly flat.

Then, beneath a charred plank, he saw a small metal handle.

Philip crouched beside it. The plank was blackened and beginning to crumble at the edges. He found a branch sturdy enough to lift it and eased the wood away a little at a time. Ash fell into the gap. The handle remained.

The dwarven box lay partly buried under the broken frame of the wagon. Its lid was scorched, one corner dented, but the lock was still shut.

Philip reached for it, then stopped. Father had said he would open it in Malcore.

The wreckage gave a dry crack behind him. Philip looked at the box, then at Father lying on the grass.

Malcore was a long way from where they were.

CHAPTER SIX

The Knife in the Box

The key was still in Father's vest pocket.

Philip had found it while checking his father for other injuries, though he had not meant to take it. He had put it back at first. Then the wagon's burning frame shifted, and he saw that the box was still trapped beneath the broken plank.

Now he held the key in his palm and the dwarven box on his knees.

"You said Malcore," he whispered.

Father's only answer was a breath through his nose.

Philip could still feel the key's shape from the first time he took it out. The small teeth had pressed into his palm. Father had kept it close, in the inner pocket of his vest, as if the lock and the promise belonged together. Philip had put it back, but now the box was half-buried under the wreckage and the promise was several days away, if they were lucky.

Philip fitted the key into the lock. It resisted at first. He turned it more gently, feeling for the place where its teeth settled. There was a small click. The lid lifted a fraction of an inch.

The box had not burned through. Its outer wood was scorched and one hinge bent, but the inside was dry. The craftsmanship had held because the joints were close and the lid fit snugly, not because the box had been made invulnerable. A good box did not need magic to be useful. It only needed someone to build it properly.

Philip ran a thumb along the edge where the lid met the base. The seam was almost too narrow to see. A line of small pins held the hinge plates in place, each one fitted so closely

that the fire had blackened the wood without loosening the metal. He had seen careful work in the shop: a barrel hoop set straight, a lock with its teeth filed evenly, a scale weight balanced until it sat true. This was the same sort of care, only made by hands that knew more about metal than he did.

He wondered whether the box had been made for the dagger or whether someone had found the box and chosen it because it fit. There was no mark on the lid, no sign of ownership. The lock had no keyhole visible until he turned it toward the light.

Inside lay a dagger.

It was longer than Philip's hand and thinner than the knives in the kitchen. The blade had a clean, bright edge, with a shallow groove running along each side. The hilt was wrapped in dark leather. Fine lines had been cut into the metal near the guard: not decoration exactly, though they had been made with care. They reminded him of the old road fitting set in the wall above the ravine.

The guard was narrow and plain. At the end of the hilt, a small metal ring had been set into the pommel. It might have been for a thong or a loop. Philip turned the dagger slowly, looking for a maker's mark, a name, anything that would tell him who had made it and why Father had kept it locked away. The grooves ended just short of the handle. No letters he could read appeared on the blade.

Philip lifted it by the handle. It was light enough to balance, heavy enough to matter. The blade was sharp. He tested it against a loose strip of cloth, not his thumb.

The edge parted the cloth cleanly. Philip used the cut strip to replace the bloodied wrap at his hairline, then sheathed the blade before he could mistake ordinary sharpness for any other kind of power. It was a good knife. That was already enough to be careful with.

He had no wish to become a fighter. But a person could dislike knives and still need to know what one was for.

Father had called it a gift from the Slayers. He had not said what it did, or why he had carried it for years without opening the box. Philip turned the knife over. Its leather grip was worn smooth where a hand had held it many times.

He looked toward the slope. The broken road was visible above the clearing, a jagged strip of stone against the sky. The iron fitting he had noticed in the wall was gone from its place. A piece of the wall had fallen with the road and lay among the debris not far from the wagon.

Philip tucked the dagger into his belt and climbed toward it.

He did not climb far. The slope was loose, and his head throbbed whenever he moved too quickly. He took one step, tested it, then another. At the base of the fallen wall, the iron fitting was half buried in a slab of stone. The grooves he had seen from above were visible through a crack.

The fitting had been made to sit flush with the road wall. Its face was roughly the length of Philip's forearm, dark with age, and split by a crack that crossed the narrow grooves. Rain had left a shallow puddle beneath it. Leaves and grit drifted slowly in the water, collecting at one end where the stone tilted.

Philip stopped before touching it.

There was no reason to bring the knife near the fitting. He had no reason to believe they were connected. The grooves might only be a mark left by some old craftsman. The blade might be nothing more than a good blade.

He took it from his belt anyway.

At first, nothing happened. Philip held the dagger out and turned it once in the gray light. The metal remained still. He felt foolish, and he was about to put it away when the hilt warmed beneath his fingers.

A faint vibration traveled through the blade.

Philip froze. The feeling did not come from the stone or the ground. It was small, more like a tremor in a taut string than a sound. His wrist seemed to lean toward the trees. The

blade did not move on its own, but the direction felt unmistakable.

The movement was not in his hand. His fingers held the hilt steady, yet for an instant he had the impression that something had passed through the road and carried the blade's attention with it. The feeling vanished when he drew the knife back.

He lowered it. The vibration stopped.

He raised it again, keeping it near the cracked fitting. The warmth returned, followed by the faint shiver. This time Philip felt the direction as a brief impression of movement: a path drawn through the trees, then gone before he could see where it led.

His stomach tightened. He lowered the dagger and sat on the stone. The rocks seemed to have shifted under him, though they had not. His head already hurt from the fall, and he could not tell whether this was more of the same or something new.

The woods lay below the broken road. If the knife pointed toward a path, perhaps it pointed toward the way out. Perhaps it pointed toward the river. Perhaps it was only a badly balanced blade and a tired boy's imagination.

The sensation had seemed real. So had the wagon tipping before it fell.

Philip rubbed the hilt with his thumb. "What are you supposed to do?"

The dagger gave no answer. It was, after all, a dagger.

He considered trying again. Then he looked down the slope at Father. His breathing was shallow but steady. The light was fading, his head hurt, and the ground did not look like a safe place to practice anything he did not understand.

Philip slid the knife back into its leather sheath and returned to Father. He set the open box beside him, then changed his mind and closed it again. He had the key, but he did not lock it. The bent hinge caught against the rim.

He slipped the key into his pocket. The dagger stayed at his belt, not because he knew what to do with it, but because leaving it in the open box felt like another kind of answer he was not ready to give.

The sky darkened behind the trees. Philip pulled his coat around Father's shoulders and sat close enough to feel each breath. He did not follow the direction the knife had shown him. He did not know what that direction meant.

The question stayed with him after the light was gone.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Berry Tree

Philip did not sleep so much as stop noticing the dark for a while.

He sat close to Father with the coat drawn over both their shoulders. Every time Father's breathing changed, Philip opened his eyes. Every time the fire settled with a crack, he opened them again. Eventually the night thinned enough that the trees became shapes instead of a wall.

His stomach hurt. He had not eaten since the stew at home. The thought of food kept returning with the stubbornness of a customer who had already been told the shop was closed.

Father did not wake.

By the time the first gray light reached the clearing, hunger had become more urgent than fear. Philip could not keep waiting for the world to improve on its own. He stood, slowly, and looked toward the tree line.

He checked Father once more before leaving. The cloth at his hairline had dried stiff, and Philip loosened it enough to see whether the cut had begun bleeding again. It had not. He listened for breath, counted five, then counted five more. Father's chest rose beneath the coat. Philip pressed two fingers to the inside of his wrist and felt a pulse, faint but steady.

Philip had no clean water and no food he could find. The horses were gone. The wagon had burned. If he went searching for help, Father would be alone with a head wound and a leg that lay at the wrong angle. If he stayed, they would both remain hungry.

He considered climbing down toward the river. The bank was hidden by brush and the slope dropped sharply below the clearing. A fall would leave Father alone with one injured boy instead of one injured boy and a hungry one. Philip decided against it. Water was necessary. So was getting there alive.

"I'll be close," Philip told him.

He stepped away only as far as he could still see Father between the wreckage and the scrub. The nearest trees began at the edge of the clearing. He looked for anything he recognized: familiar leaves, low branches, signs of an animal path. He knew enough about plants to tell a berry from a nut and not enough to tell every berry from every other berry. It was a narrow sort of knowledge, but it was the sort he had.

A squirrel darted across a fallen branch.

Philip followed it.

The squirrel climbed a tree, ran along a limb, and stopped with its tail upright. Philip tried to circle around the trunk without making a sound. He had no snare and no idea how to make one. His plan was to get close enough to catch it by hand, which was not much of a plan, but hunger had been known to improve bad ideas.

The squirrel saw him. It left by a route Philip had not noticed.

He searched beneath the roots and checked the next tree. The squirrel reappeared above him, holding something in its mouth. Philip took a step. It vanished again.

Philip tried to guess where it would come down. He chose a patch of ground below the next tree and waited, keeping still. The squirrel appeared on a branch behind him. It dropped to a root, crossed the clearing, and disappeared into a hole in a stump. Philip watched the stump for a long moment. He did not reach inside. A person could make a poor situation worse by grabbing at whatever lived in it.

He followed it twice more before he understood that he was doing exactly what it wanted. The squirrel was either

leading him away from the clearing or had discovered the most reliable form of entertainment in the forest.

Philip went back.

He found a patch of dark berries on a low bush near the broken road. The fruit grew in small clusters, with tiny hairs along the stems. He had seen them in baskets at the shop and knew their taste, though he could not remember what the supplier called them. He ate one. It was tart and soft, and it did not make his mouth numb.

That was not proof of safety. It was the best test he had.

He waited. Nothing happened except that his mouth watered for another. After a few minutes he ate one more, then one more. He kept the rest separate until he was sure they were the same kind. The shop had taught him that a label was only useful if it matched the thing inside the basket.

He gathered a handful and left the rest on the bush. The berries were not a meal, but they gave his stomach something to consider besides itself.

Philip filled the bent cup with berries, then carried it to the edge of the clearing and looked for water. The river was visible only in a few flashes through the trees. Between them and it lay a slope of loose stone and thorn. He could not see where the bank began, and the sound of the current came from farther away than he expected.

He tried collecting dew from the broad leaves. A few drops gathered in the bottom of the cup, each one carrying a fleck of dirt. He wiped the cup clean and tried again, holding it beneath a low branch while the last water shook loose. The handful he collected would not have filled a spoon. He drank it anyway, then regretted how little it changed.

On the return, he checked the ground for tracks. The soil near the trees had been pressed by small paws and by something much heavier. The larger marks were too broken to read. Philip crouched to measure one against his hand, then stopped when his head began to throb. He could not tell

whether it was a footprint or a place where the rain had washed away the earth.

He left it alone. He had no reason to put his injured hand in a hole he could not understand.

A bramble had climbed the tree, and higher clusters hung just beyond his reach. Philip could reach them if he climbed the trunk. He looked at the tree, then at his swollen right hand.

He could try with the other hand. He could use the lower limbs. He could stop if it hurt too much.

That was three plans, which was more than he had had for the squirrel.

The first branch held. Philip put his foot against the trunk and pulled himself up. The second branch bent beneath him. He eased his weight back and shifted to a thicker limb. He moved slowly, testing each hold before he trusted it. The tree was old, its bark rough enough to catch his sleeve. It was also taller than it had looked from the ground, which was a common quality among trees.

He reached the fruit. His fingers closed around a cluster. The branch flexed.

Philip stopped with the berries in his hand and studied the trunk below him. The way down looked different from the way up. This was a familiar trick of heights: they made every path seem simpler from the bottom, where the ground was kind enough to wait.

He could reach another cluster if he moved out along the branch. He could also come down with what he had. The berries in his fist were enough for one small meal, not enough for the journey. Still, he was already shaking, and the tree had begun to creak.

Philip stopped moving. The limb creaked under him. He pressed his body toward the trunk and waited for the sound to fade.

The wind moved through the leaves. Somewhere above, a bird gave a sharp call and flew away.

Then the ground trembled.

It was faint, more a shiver through the tree than a shake. Philip's cheek brushed the bark. A few leaves drifted down. At the edge of the clearing, birds burst from the brush all at once, their wings beating through the branches.

Philip held on and listened.

Nothing followed. No roar. No crash. Only the settling leaves and the distant river.

He climbed down a little too quickly. A twig snapped under his boot. He slipped, struck his right hand against the trunk, and dropped the last few feet onto the ground.

Pain shot through his knuckles. He sat where he landed and held his hand against his chest until the sharpness passed. The berries were still in his other hand, crushed but mostly whole.

The tree had not killed him. It had merely made its opinion clear.

Philip gathered the fruit that had fallen and walked back to Father. He set a few berries beside him, then ate the rest one at a time. He could have climbed again. There were more berries higher up. But his hand was worse, his head was throbbing, and the clearing seemed to tilt if he turned too fast.

He stopped.

The decision disappointed him. It also felt sensible. There was a difference between learning he could climb a tree and pretending the first climb had made him an expert.

He checked his hand. The swelling had worsened, and the skin across one knuckle had split again. He brushed grit from it as best he could, then tied the cleanest corner of the old cloth around it. The tin cup was empty. He saved it anyway, in case they found water later.

The ground shivered once more, too slight to move the stones but enough to set a tin cup rolling through the grass. Philip caught it with his foot. He looked toward the trees. Nothing moved except the branches.

When dawn finally reached the clearing, it showed him the north road.

A slide of rock and dirt had buried the narrow shelf behind them. The river below had swollen into a muddy, fast-moving band. Even if the climb back up were possible, there was no clear way to turn north and cross the water.

He climbed as far as the base of the slide and looked for a gap. The rocks were slick with fresh soil. One had rolled into the road with enough force to break the stone beside it. Philip tested the edge with his boot and felt gravel give way. He backed down. From there he could see the river's surface, which carried branches and foam in the same direction: south.

Philip knelt beside Father. "I'm going to find a way out."

Father did not stir.

Philip looked once at the fallen road, then at the forest to the south. The berries had not made him strong. They had only made it possible to stand up and keep looking.

CHAPTER EIGHT

A Stretcher and a Choice

Philip spent the first hour of the morning trying to move Father without moving the broken part of his leg.

He began by pulling the coat beneath Father's shoulders. That turned him a little, but when Philip tried to drag him, the leg scraped against a stone. Father made a low sound in his sleep. Philip let go so quickly he nearly fell backward.

"Sorry," he said.

He waited. Father's eyes remained closed. The breathing continued, uneven but present.

Philip had seen men lift barrels, crates, and once a sleeping customer who had fallen asleep on a flour sack and refused to wake for closing. Father weighed more than any of them. Philip's shoulder still ached from the crash, and his hand had become a tight, throbbing knot. He was not strong enough to carry Father in his arms. He could only make the ground do some of the work.

The land sloped gently toward the river. Above them, the Shelf Road ended in a ragged edge where the slide had taken it. Philip could see the lower route beyond a stand of pines, but the river had spilled over its banks and flooded the flat ground between. The water carried branches and pieces of bark. He could not tell how deep it was, and the current would not care if he guessed wrong.

The north road was gone. The crossing was unsafe. Malcore lay downstream.

Philip did not like the last part. It was not a place he knew how to reach on foot, and the forest stood between him and the road. But Father had said the wagon should make the trip

easier than walking. The wagon was gone. The direction remained.

He needed a way to carry Father.

The cargo canvas had torn free of the wagon frame. Most of it had burned, but a long strip remained trapped beneath a wheel. Philip used a fallen branch to pull it loose. The canvas was scorched and filthy, with one edge frayed through. He shook out the ash and found two lengths of straight wood from the broken bed.

He laid them parallel on the ground. Father was longer than the space between them, and the branches were too far apart. Philip measured with his arms, moved them, and measured again. The frame wobbled when he pushed the ends. He added a crosspiece, then another, tying the wood together with torn strips from the canvas and a length of harness webbing he found under a crate.

The first knot came loose when he tested it.

Philip swore under his breath. The knot had looked tight. He pulled the strip free and watched how the cloth had folded over itself. It had slipped because he had tied it against the branch's curve instead of around the narrow part. He tried again on a straighter section, leaving enough tail to pull hard without tearing the canvas.

The second knot held. Philip pushed down on the joint, then lifted. He leaned his weight into it with his left shoulder. The wood creaked but stayed together.

He did not trust it yet.

The next crosspiece was too short. He trimmed another branch with the sharp edge of his belt knife, keeping his bad hand away from the blade. The cut was uneven. He tested it against the opposite pole and found a gap on one side. He wedged a strip of wood into it, then tied the joint again.

His fingers cramped. He rested them on his knee until he could close them.

The second held. Philip pulled hard enough to make his sore hand throb. The branch bent but did not break.

He found one more branch, shorter and straighter than the others, and placed it across the middle. The first frame had flexed like a basket with a missing side. This one stayed square when he pushed at each corner. He sat on the canvas bed with most of his weight, then stood and checked the knots again. One had begun to slip. He tied it a third time, using his left hand to pull the strip tight.

The stretcher looked more like a pair of sticks that had agreed to remain together than a proper piece of equipment. It would have to do. Philip folded the remaining canvas over the frame to make a bed for Father. He put his coat beneath the head and kept the leg straight, as best he could.

Before risking Father's weight, Philip laid his travel bag in the middle of the canvas and lifted one end. The poles flexed, but the knots stayed. He dragged the frame three paces over the grass, stopped, and checked every tie. The center joint had loosened. He reinforced it with a second strip of webbing and pulled until his injured hand refused to close. He finished the knot with his left, then tested it again.

Moving Father onto the stretcher took both hands and all the care Philip could manage. He used the coat to lift his shoulders, then slid the canvas under him in small pulls. Father groaned when his leg shifted. Philip stopped, waited for his breathing to settle, and tried again from a different angle. His own shoulder trembled with the effort. He could not carry Father in his arms; he could carry the frame if the frame held.

The first time he lifted the poles, Father's shoulder slid toward the edge. Philip lowered him at once and retied the canvas around the frame. He checked each strap by pulling it before he tried again. The stretcher moved three paces across the grass. The poles bowed. The center tie held.

The river rope had been a straight line to safety. This was a line that had to carry a person. Philip tested every knot as if it were the iron ring at the bank. Then he set the stretcher down, studied how Father's head rested against the folded coat, and shifted the cloth so the injured leg stayed straight.

Father stirred.

Philip was beside him at once. "Father?"

His eyelids moved. He tried to lift his head, then stopped with a pained breath.

"Don't move," Philip said. "Your leg is hurt."

Father blinked at the sky. "Where?"

"Below the road. The wagon went over."

"The horses?"

"They got away."

Father closed his eyes. "Good."

Philip leaned close enough to hear him. "Where do we go?"

"Malcore."

"The north road is blocked. The river's too high to cross."

"South," Father said. "Downstream. There's a healer in Malcore."

"I know."

Father's eyes opened again, but they did not settle on Philip. "Keep to the road."

"Which road?"

Father's mouth moved, and no sound came. His eyes closed. His breathing continued.

Philip waited for him to wake again. He counted ten breaths, then ten more. Father did not speak.

"A healer," Philip repeated, so he would remember the word if his head started to swim again. "Malcore. South."

He looked at the old road fitting still half buried near the wreck. The dagger had given him a feeling toward the trees, but it had not shown him a direction he could trust. Father had named the city and the healer. The river and the slope gave the rest. Philip did not know the way through the forest, but he knew which way downstream was.

The decision was his now. He could wait where they were and hope someone found them. He could climb back to the road and search for the horses. He could try to carry Father north, though the slide had buried the route and the river had

made a wall of itself. Or he could go south, toward a place Father knew and a healer he had never met.

Philip pictured the path home: the shop door, the ledger, the warm kitchen above it. He could imagine setting Father in a room and waiting for help to arrive from Hazelwood. The picture was so clear that for a moment it felt like a choice. Then he looked again at the flooded river. The old road was buried. There was no bridge in sight. Wanting to go north did not make north possible.

Philip looked at the stretcher. Its knots held. He looked at the river. The current carried a broken branch past the flooded bank and out of sight.

"We're going south," he said.

It was not because Father had ordered him to. It was because the road north was blocked, the crossing was unsafe, and Father needed help. The choice frightened him. That did not make it a bad choice.

Philip gathered what little remained: the cup, the bruised books, the coin purse, the scorched dwarven box, the dagger in its sheath, the key, and the strip of canvas left from the stretcher. He wrapped the box in the least damaged shirt and tucked it into the travel bag. He tied the bag beneath Father's head, where it could not bounce out. Then he lifted the front poles.

The stretcher moved a few inches. Father's weight pulled hard at Philip's shoulders. He stopped, reset his grip, and tried again.

At the edge of the trees, he looked once more at the road he could no longer take. A fox watched him from between two trunks. Its ears were upright, its tail still.

Philip bent his knees and took another step.

The fox did not follow. It only watched.

CHAPTER NINE

The Fox at the Treeline

Philip made it to the first rise before he had to set the stretcher down.

The branches pressed into his palms. His right hand had swollen overnight, and the new pain from the tree climb made it difficult to close his fingers. His shoulders trembled. The slope ahead was not steep, but it was uneven, with roots and stones hidden beneath the leaf litter.

Father lay still on the canvas. Each jolt made his breath catch. Philip tried to lift the front poles without tilting the stretcher, but the ground dropped away under one foot. The frame slid sideways.

He fell to one knee.

The back end of the stretcher began to slide downhill. Philip grabbed the pole with his good hand. The canvas rasped over a root. Father's head shifted toward the edge.

Something small struck the branch beside Philip's wrist.

The stretcher stopped moving.

Philip looked down. A red fox stood beside the rear pole, one shoulder braced against it. The fox's fur was thick along its back and darker at the paws. It was not large enough to carry a man, but it had wedged itself against the frame and halted the slide long enough for Philip to get his feet beneath him.

"Thank you," he said.

The fox moved away at once, as if gratitude were a trap.

"I wasn't helping," it said.

Philip stared.

The fox sat on the root. "You were about to lose your father down the hill."

Philip looked at Father, then back at the fox. "You're talking."

"So I've been told."

"Foxes don't talk."

"You seem to be managing."

Philip had several questions and no idea which one belonged first. His head still hurt. The woods smelled of damp leaves and smoke. The fox's mouth had moved when it spoke. That was not enough to explain anything, but it was enough to make the world larger than it had been a moment ago.

He wondered if he had struck his head badly enough to hear a fox talk. Then the fox blinked at him, patient and unimpressed, which seemed like a great deal of work for a hallucination.

"What are you?" he asked.

"A fox."

"I can see that."

"Then we agree on something."

Philip looked at the stretcher. "Can you help me move him?"

"I can help you keep him from sliding off a hill. I can't carry him."

"I didn't ask you to carry him."

"You were looking at my legs."

Philip had been. He looked away. "I was trying to work out how strong you are."

"That is usually a poor way to meet someone."

"I'm not very good at meeting people."

The fox watched him for a moment. "That much is clear."

Philip let out a breath that almost became a laugh. It hurt his ribs, so he stopped. The fox's ears turned toward the trees behind them.

"The animals are leaving this part of the forest," it said.

"Because of the giant?"

"They leave the places it has passed through. The ground shakes. Trees fall. The smaller things know before you do."

"Did you see it?"

"I saw what it did to my territory." The fox's mouth pulled back, showing small white teeth. "My den is still there. The mice are not."

Philip glanced toward the north. He thought of the tremor beneath the berry tree and the birds fleeing the brush.

"Will it come this way?"

"Everything comes this way if the other way is blocked."

"That sounds like something Father would say."

"Then your father may be less foolish than he looks."

Philip was not sure how to respond to that. He set the stretcher poles down more carefully and retied the canvas at Father's shoulder. The fox paced nearby, not close enough to be caught and not far enough to be ignored.

"Do you know a path to the road?" Philip asked.

"There are many paths."

"One that doesn't go through the river."

"That leaves fewer."

"I need to reach Malcore."

"You need to move your father without breaking the stretcher. Malcore is a problem for later."

"That's what I'm trying to do."

"You're trying to do it on ground that slopes toward the river."

Philip looked at the path behind him. The fox was right. He had been watching Father's face and the poles in his hands, not the tilt of the ground. The trail narrowed toward a wet hollow.

"Where would you go?"

"Higher."

"Why?"

"Because I know where the ground stays dry."

"Does the giant know that too?"

"It has been walking on the dry ground."

"Then won't we be following it?"

Filroy looked toward the trees where the corridor had cut through the forest. "A path can belong to more than one traveler. The giant does not own the hill because it crossed it."

"I don't want to get near it."

"Then don't follow the prints. Follow the ground that holds."

Philip looked down at Father's stretcher. "If you show me the higher route, I'll decide at each part whether it's safe enough."

"That is what I would do."

"You're a fox."

"I am aware."

"Will you show me?"

The fox looked toward the disturbed trees. "I have reasons to know the dry ground."

Philip waited for more. None came. The fox did not owe him a history, and Philip did not have the strength to pull one out of him.

Philip looked at him. "You're right."

The fox seemed surprised. "That was easy."

"I'm too tired to argue."

"A useful quality."

Philip shifted his grip. "What should I call you?"

"Filroy Foxman."

"Mr. Fox?"

"That is not my name."

"It is what I can remember while carrying my father."

"Then remember Filroy."

"I'll try, Mr. Fox."

Filroy sighed as if the forest had burdened him with a difficult child. He walked ahead a little, stopping at a stretch of ground where the brush thinned and the earth rose above the wet lowland.

Philip followed with the stretcher. The frame caught on a root. He stopped, eased the front pole sideways, then waited

while Filroy tested the ground with one paw. The fox walked around the root and pointed his nose toward a narrow rise. There was no trail there that Philip could see, only leaves and a row of stones almost hidden beneath the moss.

"That's not marked," Philip said.

"It is to me."

Philip looked at the stones. He could not tell whether they were a path, the remains of an old wall, or just rocks that had ended up in a row. He did not ask the wayknife to decide. He tested the first step with his boot.

It held.

"There," he said. "A marked trail. It stays on higher ground for a while."

Philip looked for the mark. A pale strip of bark had been cut from a tree at shoulder height, and a second mark appeared farther along the path. It was not a sign he recognized, only a plain trail blaze.

"Does it go south?"

"It goes where it goes."

Philip tightened the strap around Father's shoulder and tested the knot with a tug. Then he lifted the poles again, slowly enough to feel the frame take the weight.

He waited until Filroy had moved ahead, then tried lifting the rear poles by himself. The stretcher rose an inch and dragged his shoulder down. He set it back immediately.

"You cannot do that alone," Filroy said.

"I know."

"Do you?"

Philip looked at the fox. "I'm trying to know."

Filroy stopped. "Then I will walk behind the stretcher on the steep places. I will not pull it for you."

"That's enough."

"It is what I offered."

"I'll see where it goes," he said.

Filroy turned his ears toward the forest and started along the marked trail.

The first stretch climbed between two patches of wet ground. Philip tested every step with his boot and used the branch when the trail narrowed. Filroy moved ahead, pausing where the earth changed color. He never waited so long that Philip could mistake him for a servant.

At a low stone, Philip stopped to adjust the stretcher. Father's shoulder had slipped toward the edge again. Philip tightened the canvas and checked the knot. Filroy watched from the next rise.

"You can tell me if the ground turns bad," Philip said.

"I will."

"And if you don't know?"

"I will tell you that too."

Philip took a breath. "Good."

The path passed a narrow stream and crossed an old line of stones. Philip looked for a marker, but the stones had no iron fittings. The wayknife stayed quiet at his belt. He did not take it out just to see whether it would answer. He could hear the stream and see the rise beyond it. For now, those were enough.

They moved another dozen paces before Philip had to stop. He set the stretcher down on level ground and waited for his arms to stop trembling. Filroy paced the ridge, alert to the forest behind them.

"You'll need more rests," the fox said.

"I know."

"You are not walking quickly enough to pretend otherwise."

Philip looked at the stretcher. "I'm not trying to walk quickly."

"Good. The forest does not reward speed."

CHAPTER TEN

A Road with No Road

The marked trail kept to higher ground until it did not.

For a while Philip could follow it by the pale cuts on the trees. The stretcher dragged over roots and stones, and every few steps he had to stop to shift his grip. Filroy moved ahead, vanished behind brush, then reappeared on the other side of a fallen branch.

"This path is older than the marks," Philip said.

"Most paths are."

"I meant the trail blazes."

"I know what you meant."

Philip tried not to look at Father's face each time the stretcher jolted. He had wrapped the canvas twice around the poles, but there was no way to keep the frame smooth over uneven ground. Father's leg lay straight, his boot still pointed outward. His breathing caught now and then, then settled again.

The trail descended into a shallow hollow. Water stood among the reeds, reflecting a narrow strip of sky. On the far side, Philip saw a line of flat stones leading toward the trees. Some were missing. The rest sank into mud.

"We should go around," Filroy said.

"Around where?"

"Up."

Philip looked at the rise. It was steep and covered in wet roots. "The stretcher won't go up there."

"It won't go through the water either."

"I can test it."

Filroy's ears turned toward him. "You can test your own boot. You cannot test the ground for the weight of two people and a wooden frame."

Philip glanced at the stones. There was an old iron marker set beside the first one, its top level with his hip. The face was worn but intact, with a narrow groove running down its center. The trail seemed to continue past it, though the mud had hidden most of the way.

"I'll see if this tells us anything," he said.

"The fox has just told you something."

"I heard him."

"Then why ask the knife?"

Philip had no good answer. The wayknife had pointed toward the trees at the other marker. If it could show the road, perhaps it could settle this. He took it from his belt and moved close to the iron fitting.

The hilt warmed.

The vibration came at once, stronger than before. It ran up the blade into his wrist, then spread across his fingers. Philip felt the direction as a pulse of movement: heavy steps crossing the stones and continuing through the hollow. The rhythm was slow and uneven. The ground in his mind seemed to give way beneath each step.

He pulled back, but the impression stayed for another moment. His stomach lurched. The trees leaned sideways, though he knew they had not moved.

"Philip?" Filroy said.

Philip blinked. The fox was standing on higher ground. Father lay still on the stretcher.

"It points across," Philip said.

"What does?"

"The knife. The road."

"It points to where people have gone."

Philip tightened his hand around the hilt. "That's a road."

Filroy looked at the submerged stones. "It was."

Philip studied the marker. The path continued across the hollow in a clear direction. He felt a faint dizziness, but it seemed to be fading. The heavy steps had gone that way. The old road had gone that way. It was the best answer he had.

He put the knife away.

"We'll cross at the stones," he said.

Filroy did not argue. He moved to the edge and sniffed the air, then stepped onto a patch of grass that held his weight. Philip took the stretcher's front poles. The first stones were firm beneath his boots. The water reached his ankles, cold through the leather. He placed each foot carefully, pausing at the gaps where mud covered the path.

Halfway across, the rear of the stretcher dropped.

The canvas pulled tight. Father's shoulder slid toward the edge. Philip turned, reaching to steady him, and the water reached his knees. The ground beneath his left foot gave way. He caught the nearest stone with his free hand.

"Don't pull!" Filroy called.

Philip stopped. The stretcher shifted again, but the canvas held. The stone under his hand was slick. He looked at the path behind him. The water was cloudy now, stirred by his boots. He could not see the bottom.

"The marker says—"

"The marker says nothing about your weight."

Philip swallowed. He had thought the reading would lead to a route. It had led him to a road that no longer existed in any useful sense.

He backed toward the nearest firm stone, moving one foot at a time. The stretcher caught on a submerged rock. He lifted, then lowered it carefully. Father groaned when the frame jolted. Philip stopped and waited, his arms shaking.

They reached the bank by inches. Filroy kept to the higher grass and watched Philip test each step. When the stretcher was safely on dry ground again, Philip sat down hard. The wayknife's vibration had stopped, but his stomach still rolled.

He kept hold of the front pole even after the stretcher stopped. His fingers had locked around the wood. When he tried to open them, his right hand did not cooperate. He eased each finger loose with the other hand and looked at the water. A dark line of silt moved away from where they had crossed. The stones were still there beneath it, but the crossing had ceased to be a path as soon as they needed it.

"Father?" he said.

Father's eyes were closed. The stretcher had shifted against the bank, but the lashings still held. Philip checked the injured leg without touching it, then the blanket, then Father's face. He was breathing. Philip repeated the checks because the first attempt had been too fast to count as certainty.

Filroy walked the bank and found a narrow strip of ground behind a clump of alder. It was too low for the stretcher to pass, but above the waterline. He returned and sniffed the mud on Philip's boot.

"The stones slope down on the far side," he said. "There is no dry exit."

"The marker showed the road crossing."

"It showed that something crossed it."

Philip looked down at the wayknife. His first reading had seemed like a path laid out for him. It had not shown him the mud, the depth, or the way the stones ended under the far bank. He had supplied those answers himself.

"I should have checked the far side before we moved him."

"Yes."

Philip did not argue. His mistake had made Father hurt more, though he did not know by how much. He could not undo the crossing. He could keep from making the same one again.

He sheathed the knife and fastened it at his belt again. Then he took the branch and tested the ground beside the water, looking for a route that did not depend on the submerged stones.

"I thought it meant safe," he said.

"It meant traveled."

Philip looked at the marker across the water. "How do you know?"

"I don't. I know the ground."

Philip turned the dagger in its sheath until the hilt no longer pressed against his belt. "I need to look at the ground."

"Yes."

"And I need you to tell me what you see."

Filroy's tail moved once. "That is better."

Philip reached for the stretcher poles again. Father made a small sound, almost a groan. His eyelids fluttered.

"Father?"

His eyelids did not lift, but his hand moved against the canvas, and the sound that came from him was unmistakably a word.

"Philip."

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Half Awake

Father woke in pieces.

First his eyes opened, then shut. A while later, his fingers found the edge of the blanket. When Philip spoke, Father turned his head toward the sound but did not seem to know where it came from.

They had reached a dry rise beyond the flooded hollow. Philip had stopped there because Father's breathing had grown worse and his own legs would no longer keep the stretcher moving. Filroy had found a patch of ground where the brush broke the wind. The fox watched from a few steps away, pretending not to watch.

"Don't move," Philip said.

Father frowned. "Where are we?"

"South of the crash. On a dry rise."

"The road?"

"The road went into the swamp."

Father tried to lift his shoulders. His face tightened, and he sank back against the folded coat.

"Stay still," Philip said again. "Your leg is hurt."

"I know."

"You knew before you tried to move it?"

"I know now."

Philip sat back on his heels. He wanted to be angry. He was angry. But Father's face was gray under the dirt, and there was a tremor in his voice that had not been there before.

"The wayknife led us to the flooded crossing," Philip said.

Father's eyes shifted toward the dagger at Philip's belt. "You used it?"

"I brought it near the marker. It showed a path through the water."

"It showed you traffic."

"I didn't know that."

Father closed his eyes. "I should have told you."

Philip stared at him. "You gave me a knife I didn't understand, then let me try to use it while you were unconscious."

"I thought I'd explain it in Malcore."

"You said that about the box. You said that about the trip. You keep deciding when I'm allowed to know things."

Father's breathing rasped. "You're fifteen. You're hurt. I was trying to keep you safe."

"Being kept ignorant isn't the same as being kept safe."

"I know."

"Do you?"

Father's eyes opened again. He looked directly at Philip this time. "I know it now."

The words did not make the anger disappear. They did make it harder to keep using it as a wall.

Philip pointed to the blade. "What does it do?"

"It's a wayknife. It reads a worked marker. The stone holds traces of repeated passage, and the knife lets you feel the strongest line."

"The strongest line?"

"The route most used. Or the route that left the greatest impression."

"How close do you have to be?"

"Within reach of the marker. It has to be worked stone or iron, and there has to be enough of it left to hold the trace."

"So not just any road."

"No. The knife can't find a path through the forest." Father blinked slowly. "It reads the marker. The rest is yours."

"That was the heavy steps."

"Probably."

"And it doesn't know if the route is safe?"

"No."

"Does it know where the route ends?"

"No."

"Then it doesn't tell you much."

Father almost smiled. "It tells you one thing. You have to find out what that thing means."

Philip thought of the river rope. It had led somewhere because it was attached to the bank. He had checked the iron ring before trusting it. The marker had given him direction, but he had treated that direction as a decision.

"Why give it to me if you weren't going to explain it?"

"I planned to."

"When?"

"In Malcore. When we weren't trying to keep you alive on a hillside."

"You knew we might have trouble."

Father's gaze left him. "I knew there was danger on the road."

"And you didn't tell me."

"I wanted to."

"You didn't."

For a few seconds neither of them spoke. The forest moved around them in small sounds: water slipping through reeds, a bird calling once and then falling silent, Filroy's claws on a stone.

"I thought if I told you about the Slayers, you'd think I wanted you to become one," Father said. "I thought the knife would feel like a claim."

"It feels like a claim when you give me something and won't tell me what it is."

"I see that."

"You keep telling me to fight. Then you give me a tool I don't understand and expect me to choose the right path."

"I didn't expect you to use it yet."

"Then why did you bring it?"

Father did not answer. His eyes had begun to close again.

Philip leaned closer. "I need you to tell me what you know."

"I will."

"Now."

"Not all of it." Father swallowed. "I can tell you how the knife works. I can't tell you everything about the Slayers while I can barely keep my eyes open."

Philip looked at the wayknife. "That's still more than you told me before."

"Yes."

Father shifted his hand, then winced. "The marker can be damaged. The reading can be wrong or incomplete. The hilt warms. You feel a direction and a rhythm. Then you stop and look around. If the ground disagrees, believe the ground."

"How do you know which part is old and which part is new?" Philip asked.

"You learn the feel of a trace. Regular steps, carts, a crowd, a heavier thing. You compare what the knife tells you with what you can see."

"You could tell the giant's steps from a cart?"

"I could tell they were heavy and uneven. I couldn't tell what the giant wanted."

"How many times can you read it?"

Father's eyes closed, then opened again. "Once, properly. Twice if you're careful. More than that and you stop knowing whether the marker is moving or you are."

Philip glanced at the flooded crossing. "I read it."

"Then stop."

"I already did."

"Good." Father's voice weakened. "A reader learns to stop before he needs to."

"And if the ground is under water?"

"Then don't step into it."

Filroy made a small sound that might have been agreement.

Philip looked at the fox. "You could have said that."

"I did," Filroy said. "You were busy asking the knife."

Father's mouth twitched. "He's right."

Philip looked at him, waiting to see whether Father would add a reason or turn the admission into another instruction. Father only let out a slow breath.

"I should have told you before you had to use it."

"Yes."

"I thought the trip would be easier."

"Because the knife was in the box?"

"Because the road was familiar."

"It isn't anymore."

Father looked toward the swamp. "No."

Philip wanted to ask what else was in the old road. He also wanted Father to stay awake long enough to answer. He chose the question that might help them travel.

"What should I do if a marker gives me two directions?"

"Step away. Wait until you can stand straight. Then look at the land. Ask what the road is doing. Don't ask the knife to choose for you."

"And if I can't tell?"

"Ask someone else."

Filroy lifted his head. "That is a reasonable answer."

"That's twice today," Philip said. "The forest is becoming difficult."

The brief smile left Father's face. "I'm sorry I didn't explain."

Philip did not answer at once. The apology was real. So was the hurt. Neither one made the other disappear.

"I need you to help me," Philip said. "You know the roads. I don't."

"I can tell you what I remember."

"And I need to tell you what I see. Even if it doesn't match what you remember."

Father looked at him for a long moment. "All right."

It was not a grand agreement. It was a tired man on a stretcher giving his son one word. Philip decided to take it for what it was.

Father's eyes closed. This time Philip did not try to wake him.

Filroy was already watching the slope below. "The wet path is not the only way through."

Philip picked up the branch he had used to test the mud. "Show me the other one."

"I'll show you the beginning. You'll have to test each step."

Philip checked the stretcher knots, then set the wayknife back in its sheath. "At first light."

"The ground will still be there."

"That's what I'm hoping."

He settled beside Father and kept watch until the dark thinned. He did not sleep much, but he rested his legs and kept one hand near the stretcher. When the first light reached the swamp, he and Filroy started toward the higher ground.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Swamp's False Road

At first light, the higher trail began as a line of animal prints in the mud.

Filroy led them along the edge of the swamp, where the ground rose in narrow shelves between pools of standing water. He did not hurry. Philip was grateful for that. Every step with the stretcher asked for more strength than the one before it, and he had very little to spend.

The old road ran below them. At one point, a marker stone stood at the edge of a shallow channel. Its top was tilted, and the old track seemed to continue across the mud beyond it. Philip could see a row of stone shapes beneath the water, each one partly covered by brown silt.

"That's the road," he said.

Filroy sniffed the air. "It was a road."

The phrase had become familiar. Philip did not like how often the past tense appeared in the forest.

He took the branch and pressed it into the ground ahead of him. The tip sank through the mud until it struck stone. He moved the branch to the side. It sank deeper. He tried a third place, and it went through to the handle.

"The path is there," he said.

"The mud is there too."

"If we follow the stones—"

"You will find out how deep the mud is."

Philip looked at the stretcher. Father had not stirred since the dry rise. The canvas was stained where his leg rested. His lips had begun to crack. They needed water, but the swamp

water was full of silt and leaves, and Philip had no way to make it safe.

He wanted to use the wayknife. Father had told him the marker held traces of travel, not a promise that the route would bear them. He had just watched the old road disappear under mud. The knife could not make the path firm.

"Where do the animals go?" he asked.

Filroy walked to a bank of grass and pressed one paw against it. The ground held. He followed the line of prints up a slight rise, then turned where the reeds thinned.

"They stay above the water."

"That's a trail?"

"It is if you are small."

"I'm carrying someone."

"Then you should be glad you are not carrying two people."

Philip did not have an answer to that. He tested the first section with his branch. The ground was firm for three steps, then soft where a narrow stream crossed under the grass. He shifted the stretcher poles higher and asked Filroy to wait while he probed a second route.

The path widened beneath a stand of alder. Philip pressed the branch down at regular intervals, counting the depth by finger marks. One spot held. The next sank past the first mark. He moved two feet to the left and tried again. This time the branch struck root.

"There," Filroy said.

"You could have told me."

"You were testing."

Philip glanced at him. "I was trying to find the path."

"Now you have."

They moved Father across the first shelf. Philip took the front poles while Filroy walked beside the rear, keeping the canvas from catching on the grass. The fox could not lift the stretcher, but he could warn Philip when the ground dipped or when a root crossed the track.

At the narrowest point, a branch snagged Father's coat. Philip stopped before the stretcher shifted. He lowered his end and worked the cloth free, one hand at a time. His wrapped right hand throbbed. His head pulsed in the old rhythm of the crash and the new rhythm of the day.

They rested after ten paces.

"That was ten?" Philip asked.

"If you say so."

"I counted."

"Then it was ten."

Philip drank the last drops of dew from the inside of a broad leaf. It was not enough to ease his thirst. He saved the empty cup, though he had nothing to put in it. Father's lips were dry. Philip dampened the cloth at his own collar and touched it to them. Father swallowed once without waking.

"We need water," Philip said.

"We need many things," Filroy replied. "Water is one of the more useful."

"Can you find some?"

"I can find water. I can't make it clean."

"Then show me where it is."

Filroy led them to a narrow seep coming from between two rocks, above the swamp line. The water was clear where it emerged, but Philip could not tell how far it had traveled through the mud. He let it run into the cup for a while, watching for grit. There was none. He smelled it, then tasted a drop.

It tasted of stone.

He filled the cup and gave Father a little, wetting his lips before letting him swallow. Philip took only one mouthful himself. The rest he saved.

The trail climbed gradually. Philip tested each section with the branch before moving the stretcher. When he was unsure, he asked Filroy. When Filroy was unsure, he tested another place. Neither of them pretended the other could guarantee what lay ahead.

By the time they reached firm ground, Father's breathing had grown rough again. His face was hot beneath Philip's fingers. The leg beneath the canvas had begun to swell. Philip could not tell whether the bone was broken, only that the pain was worse when they moved.

"We have to stop," he said.

Filroy looked toward the rising land. "There's a dry shelf above us."

"Can we get there?"

"You can."

Philip looked at the stretcher, then at the slope. "We'll try."

The last rise took them another half hour. Philip stopped twice. Once, his hand slipped and the stretcher shifted toward the swamp. Filroy braced the rear pole with his shoulder until Philip recovered his grip. He did not say he was helping. Philip did not make him say it.

At the top, the ground widened into a rough shelf of grass and stone. The forest opened below them. Far to the east, a broad corridor cut through the trees. Trunks lay broken across it. The earth had been pressed flat in a long, uneven line, with splintered branches pointing away from the path.

Philip lowered the stretcher onto the firm ground.

"Is that where it went?" he asked.

Filroy's ears angled toward the corridor. "Something went through there."

Philip could see no giant. He could see the damage it had left behind.

The old road had not simply been lost. Something large had found it.

Philip rested with his back against a stone. From the shelf he could see the swamp's surface moving in small circles where rain had begun to return. The water looked calm from above. He had learned that calm was sometimes only what danger looked like at a distance.

He checked the path they had taken. Their bootprints crossed the grass, then disappeared where the ground turned

to stone. Filroy's smaller tracks ran between them and the edge. The stretcher had left a wider mark, but the canvas had not torn. Philip retied the loosened corner and checked the splint. Father's foot remained warm, though the swelling had pushed against the cloth.

"How long can he stay like this?" Philip asked.

Filroy watched the corridor. "I know how long I can cross this shelf. I do not know how long a man can remain injured."

Philip nodded. He would not ask the fox to know what he could not.

The corridor was broad enough for the giant to walk without turning sideways. It continued east, hidden by a low ridge. The trees at its edges leaned outward. One had been split down the trunk, and the exposed wood was pale against the wet bark.

Philip wondered whether the giant had chosen the road or only the easiest ground. The wayknife might show where it had gone. It could not tell him whether the creature knew the road from before, or whether it had found it by chance.

He put the dagger away. There was no marker close enough to ask, and no answer in the forest that he could make by wishing.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Giant's Wake

They stayed on the shelf Filroy had found, keeping the stretcher in the shade of a stand of birch. Below them, the forest lay quiet around the broad scar Philip had noticed on the climb. There had been no easy moment since the crash, only moments in which nothing worse happened. Philip had started to recognize the difference.

Philip laid the stretcher down. He checked the lashings and lifted the blanket from Father's face long enough to see that he was breathing. Father's lips were dry. Philip poured the last spoonful of seep water into the cup and let Father drink a little. The rest he kept. It felt mean to count water by mouthfuls when Father could not ask for more, but thirst did not become less serious when ignored.

"How much?" Father murmured.

"Not much."

"For you?"

"I had some."

Philip hoped this was true enough. Filroy watched him without comment.

"The ground is bare along that line," the fox said. "The animals have gone around it."

"How far?"

"Far enough to be inconvenient."

"That's not a distance."

"It is to a fox."

Philip glanced at the corridor. It widened where it crossed the low ground and narrowed again at the foot of the hill. The forest did not look trampled by a herd. Trees lay at different

angles. Some had been torn up, roots exposed; others had been pushed aside. Between them, a series of broad impressions ran in a slow line.

"Could a landslide have done that?" Philip asked.

"A landslide does not stop at a tree," Filroy said.

The tracks were clear enough to follow with the eye, though they vanished under ferns in several places. Smaller prints crossed them, then doubled back. The animals had not all fled in the same direction. Some had circled, perhaps looking for another way to reach their dens.

Philip leaned over the stretcher. "We should move behind the rocks."

"If we move, we may make more noise," Filroy said.

"If we stay here, the stretcher is in the open."

Filroy studied the rise, then glanced at the bright canvas. "The rocks, then. Slowly."

They dragged the stretcher a few feet into the shadow of the birches. Philip set a branch beneath one pole to keep it from rolling. He checked the branch twice, then checked the slope beyond it. The hill had loose stones near the edge. If the giant came up the corridor, the stones would tell them before the trees did.

Philip stood beside the stretcher. Father's breathing was shallow beneath the coat. The fox held still near the edge of the rise, his ears turned toward the low ground.

"It went that way," Philip whispered.

"Something did," Filroy said.

The ground trembled.

Philip felt the vibration through his soles. It was deeper than the earlier tremor, strong enough to make pebbles shift on the slope. The animals in the brush went silent. A bird lifted from a dead branch and flew east.

Then the giant appeared between the trees.

It moved slowly through the corridor, taller than the surrounding pines. Its head looked like a block of weathered stone, its shoulders broad beneath a rough wrap of hides and

woven branches. One arm hung low. The other pushed aside a fallen trunk as if it were a reed.

The giant's steps made the earth shudder. Each foot came down with a pause afterward, as though the creature were listening to the ground before taking the next one. It did not hurry. It did not look toward the hill.

Philip could not make himself breathe.

He had seen drawings of giants in the shop's books. The pictures had made them seem like enormous people, only wider and more difficult to fit through a doorway. The creature in the corridor was not a person enlarged. It was a force moving through a place that had not been built for it.

The giant reached a cluster of fallen trunks. It stopped. Its head turned toward the river. For a moment Philip thought it had heard them. The wind carried smoke from the wreckage and the smell of damp leaves. Father's stretcher lay in full view on the rise.

Philip's hand went to the knife at his belt. He had no plan for what to do with it. The blade could cut, and its strange pull might tell him something about the road, but neither fact made it a weapon against a giant. He let the hilt go.

He looked at Filroy. The fox had flattened himself against a rock, ears pressed back, eyes fixed on the giant. Father's face had gone tense beneath the blanket. Philip placed one hand on the stretcher rail, not to hold it in place but because he wanted to feel something that did not move on its own.

Philip reached for the blanket and drew it over the bright canvas. Filroy pressed himself against a rock. Neither of them moved.

The giant turned away.

It stepped over the trunks and continued along the corridor, angling toward a strip of exposed stone. The path ahead was drier than the ground around it. The giant followed the open stone, leaving the low, flooded places untouched.

The creature's pace did not change. It moved as if each step were part of a decision made a long time ago and not

reconsidered since. The trees broke because they stood in the way. The stones shifted because the earth could not hold the weight. Neither seemed to be the purpose of its journey.

At the edge of the corridor, a fox's den had been cut open by a fallen root. The giant passed within a few strides of it. It did not bend toward the den or search the trees. It kept going.

Philip watched until the creature was hidden by the ridge.

Only then did he realize his knees were shaking. He sat beside the stretcher and lowered his face into his hands. His right hand throbbed beneath its wrap. He kept it closed against his chest until his breathing slowed.

Filroy crouched a few feet away, his body low to the ground. He had not taken his eyes off the corridor. "It could have reached this hill."

"It didn't."

"It could have."

"That's why we stayed quiet."

Filroy's tail stayed low. He had been still throughout the giant's passage, but now his paws shifted against the dirt as if he wanted to run and had not yet decided where.

Father stirred. Philip moved beside him and checked the blanket. "It's gone east," he said.

"The giant?"

"Yes."

"Did it see you?"

"We don't know."

Father nodded, then closed his eyes. The answer seemed to satisfy him more than a guess would have.

"It didn't see us," he said.

"No," Filroy replied.

"It didn't come for us."

"No."

Philip looked toward the broken corridor. "It could still come back."

Filroy did not answer.

They stayed on the hill until the forest began to make sounds again. A bird called once. Something small moved in the brush below. The giant's trail remained visible through the trees, a line of crushed growth and exposed earth.

Philip made himself look at the ground around the corridor. There were no signs of a chase: no scattered carcass, no prints turning back toward the animals. The giant had not swept its gaze through the forest. It had chosen the stone and kept going.

That did not make it harmless. The branch it had moved could have crushed them as easily as the fallen trunks. But danger and intention were separate things, even when they arrived together.

Philip did not know what the creature wanted. He knew only that it had moved toward the dry stone and ignored the stretcher. Fear warned him to keep away. It did not tell him what the giant intended.

Clouds gathered behind the western ridge, dark and low. The wind changed. It carried the smell of rain before the first drop fell.

Their shelter on the hill would not last through a storm.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The Route Past Home

The fork lay below the hill, where the north track split from the southbound road.

They descended slowly. Philip walked ahead with a branch, probing the leaf mold before the stretcher followed. The ground was drier along the slope, but the storm clouds had begun to thicken behind them. Every so often, a tremor ran beneath the path. It was too faint to knock anything loose, but Philip felt it in his sore hand where he leaned on the branch.

At a narrow shelf, the stretcher caught between two roots. Filroy braced the rear pole while Philip lifted the front. Father groaned. Philip froze until the sound passed.

"We should stop," Filroy said.

"We can clear the root."

"Your father needs stillness."

Philip looked at the stretcher, then at the north track. They could stop in the open, or move six more paces to a patch of higher ground where the slope widened. He hated that every choice involved guessing what kind of trouble was worse.

"Six paces," he said. "Then we stop."

They moved the stretcher. When they reached the patch, Philip knelt beside Father and checked the leg wrap. The swelling had made the cloth tight. He loosened one strip and watched Father's foot for color. The toes remained warm. Father's breathing steadied, though he did not wake.

The small cup held only a thin film of water. Philip considered giving it to Father, then remembered that water alone would not fix the injury. He wet a scrap of cloth and

touched it to Father's lips. The gesture used almost nothing. It also did not pretend to solve anything.

Philip had seen the junction on the torn map, though the paper showed two thin lines and nothing of the ground between them. From the slope, he could see the north track climbing toward the place where the road had fallen away. The river beyond it was swollen and fast. The southern road curved between two low ridges, then disappeared into the trees.

The giant's trail crossed both routes.

Philip lowered Father's stretcher onto a patch of firm ground. Father's eyes were closed, but he had begun to stir more often. His face was hot to the touch. The leg beneath the canvas had swollen further, and the skin above his boot had turned dark with bruising.

Philip took the torn map from his bag. It had dried into stiff folds, and one corner had split along a crease. He flattened it against a rock and traced the two routes with one finger. The north track returned to Hazelwood, where someone might help if they could reach the river. The south road reached Malcore, where a healer waited behind a wall. The map did not show the slide, the flood, or the storm. Maps were good at roads that stayed where they were drawn.

"We need to decide," Philip said.

Filroy looked toward the north. "You already have."

"I haven't."

"You keep looking south."

Philip glanced at the flooded river. "I'm checking."

"The river is still there."

"It could go down."

"It could."

"And if we wait?"

Filroy's ears moved toward the corridor. "The giant will keep moving."

Philip knew the northern route better. The road home ran beside the river. If he could reach it, someone in Hazelwood could send help. There would be a bed for Father, clean water,

and people who knew them. He could return to the shop and keep the rest of the world on the other side of the door.

The river had risen over its banks. The north track ended at a wall of fallen stone. The horses were gone. Father could not walk. Their food was gone, and what little water they had found was not enough.

Malcore was downstream. It had a healer. It was also the place Father had intended to reach, though he had not told Philip why.

Father moved beneath the blanket. His eyes opened, unfocused.

"Father?" Philip leaned over him. "Can you hear me?"

"The road?"

"North is blocked. The river is too high. We're at a fork."

Father swallowed. "Malcore."

"That's south."

"Go south."

"Why?"

Father's eyes drifted shut. He did not answer.

Philip waited. The only thing that moved was Father's breathing.

Philip held the cup near his father's mouth. Father swallowed once, then turned away. Philip wiped the water from his chin with the edge of his sleeve. He wanted to ask more, but Father's eyes had already closed. Philip had to decide with what he had: a broken road, a flooded river, a healer downstream, and a father who had said the same city twice.

"You can tell me why," Philip said.

Father's mouth shifted, but the words did not come. His eyes stayed closed.

The instruction had not made the choice for Philip. It had only confirmed that Father believed Malcore was the better place to go. Philip still had to decide if he agreed.

He looked north again. Home lay beyond the river and the slide. He could not reach it with Father on the stretcher. He

could not leave Father to find help alone. He could not make the water safe by wanting it to be safe.

The south road was unfamiliar, but it was open. It ran toward the city and the healer. It was the only route that matched what they needed now.

"We're going to Malcore," Philip said.

Filroy watched him. "Because your father said so?"

"Because he needs a healer. Because the north road is gone. Because the river is dangerous."

"And because you want to?"

Philip looked at the dark water. "I want to go home."

"That wasn't my question."

Philip looked at the south road. "I'm choosing Malcore. It's not the same as obeying him."

Filroy nodded once. He did not tell Philip that the choice was right.

Philip tested the stretcher knots. He checked the little cup, the wrapped box, the dagger, and the torn map. The storm clouds had grown darker behind them. Rain would reach the forest soon.

They moved toward the south road.

The road was older than the trail they had followed. A strip of stone ran beneath the leaf litter, broken in places by roots. Worked markers stood at irregular intervals. Some leaned. Others had disappeared into moss and brush. Philip did not bring the wayknife near them. He used the direction of the river, the slope of the ground, and the line of stones to keep them moving south.

Father woke once as they crossed a shallow stream. Philip stopped the stretcher and gave him a sip from the cup. The water looked clear in the light, but tasted of stone and leaves.

"Malcore," Father murmured.

"Yes."

"Road Office."

Philip leaned closer. "What about it?"

Father's brow tightened. His mouth moved, but the words dissolved into breath. He fell asleep again.

Philip looked at Filroy. The fox gave no sign that he had understood.

"I'm not asking you to explain it," Philip said.

"Good."

The first drops of rain struck the leaves. The wind pressed through the trees, carrying a low rumble that might have been thunder or the distant movement of the giant.

Philip checked the map again and marked the fork with a small slash of charcoal. He did not know if he would need to explain the route to anyone. He wanted a record of where they had chosen, in case the storm or the dark made the road feel like somewhere else.

They were not yet at the old bridge.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Stormline

The old bridge was made of stone, but the road that reached it had been made of earth.

They heard the stream before they saw the bridge. It ran fast beneath the trees, swollen from the rain that had already passed north of them. Philip stopped the stretcher on a rise and let the water's sound help him judge where the ground fell away. The path was narrow, and the trail's outer edge had slumped toward the cut.

"We should wait for daylight," Filroy said.

"The rain is coming before daylight," Philip replied.

"Then we find shelter before it reaches us."

They searched the slope for a place above the stream. The hillside offered roots and stones but no cave. The bridge abutment was the best cover they could find, and even that depended on how much water the stream carried. Philip did not like shelter that relied on the ground remaining exactly as it was. He liked it less than walking in the rain, which was how he knew the choice was not a good one.

By the time they reached it, rain had darkened the stones and turned the slope to a slick brown path. The bridge crossed a narrow cut in the ground where a stream ran toward the Big River. Its side walls were low and worn. Roots had grown through the abutment on the east bank, gripping the old stones in a tangled lattice.

Philip set the stretcher down on the bridge approach. Father's breathing was shallow and uneven. Rain ran through his hair and along the edge of the coat that covered him.

Philip checked Father's face, then his hands. Father's skin was cold. The coat was wet through at one shoulder, and the blanket beneath him had gathered water at the fold. Philip shifted it and slid a dry piece of canvas under Father's neck.

"I'm going to get you under the bridge," he said. "It'll be cramped. We'll keep your leg still."

Father's eyelids moved, but he did not answer.

"We should get below the bridge," Filroy said.

Philip looked at the bank. The eastern side sloped down toward the stream. The ground there was soft, but the rooted abutment offered some shelter from the wind.

"We'll secure the stretcher first."

He found a length of harness webbing in the pack. It was torn but strong enough to hold a few pulls. Philip tied one end around the stretcher frame and the other around a stone post at the bridge entrance. Then he tested the knot with a hard tug.

The post did not move.

Philip leaned his weight on the line, then let it slacken. The knot held, but the iron ring shifted a fraction in its socket. He tested the surrounding stone with the heel of his hand. The ring had been fixed into the abutment, though the mortar around it was cracked. A line was only as strong as what held it. The thought came from the river dock, where the bank ring had kept him from being carried downstream. Here, he needed the stone as well as the iron to keep its promise.

He threaded the webbing through a second point around the root mass, not as a replacement for the ring but as a backup. The root was thick and partly exposed. He pulled until bark creaked. It held.

He checked the ground around it. The stones were set into the bridge, but the soil had washed away from the outer edge. He moved the knot to an iron ring fixed deeper into the abutment and tested it again. The line held.

The river rope had been useful because Philip checked where it led. The harness line held because he checked what it was tied to. He did not trust a line simply because it was there.

The rain thickened. Water began running down the road in narrow streams. Filroy disappeared beneath the bridge to find a dry place, then returned to lead Philip around the east side of the abutment.

"There's a hollow under the roots," he said. "It is not deep, but it is dry above the waterline."

Philip looked at the stretcher. "Can we get him there?"

"If we move before the bank gives way."

They lifted together. Philip took the front poles. Filroy pushed against the rear frame with his shoulder, helping keep it straight. The stretcher scraped over stone. Father made a sound and clenched one hand around the blanket.

Lightning split the sky.

The flash lit the bridge, the river, and the far bank in a single white moment. A tree on the western slope caught the strike. Its upper branches burst into flame, and the trunk cracked near its base.

The fire lasted only seconds before the rain smothered it. The broken tree leaned over the path, shedding branches. One struck the stream and spun away. Philip flinched at each crack, then forced himself to watch the bank. The land beneath them had already been softened by water. The storm did not need magic to make it dangerous.

Thunder followed. The sound rolled through the ravine and came back at them from the bridge.

The bank beneath Philip's feet shifted.

He stopped. "Filroy—"

The earth gave way.

The stretcher lurched. The harness line snapped tight against the ring. Father slid toward the edge, held only by the canvas and the frame. Philip grabbed one pole with both hands.

The line held. The bank did not.

The webbing bit into Philip's palms. He could hear the fibers stretching. Filroy reached for the pole, but a wash of mud cut between them. Philip's boots slid. The stretcher tilted, canvas pulling tight across Father's chest. For one breath Philip held on with both hands and could not tell whether he was saving Father or only keeping himself attached to the fall.

Philip was thrown downhill. His shoulder struck the slope, and the side of his head hit a root. The world spun. Mud and rain filled his mouth. He rolled until a low shelf of stone stopped him.

For several seconds he could not remember his name.

Then he heard the stream and the storm. He pushed himself upright. The bridge was above him, half-hidden by rain. The stretcher hung near the abutment, caught on the line. Father was not visible.

"Father!"

The wind took the word.

Philip reached for the wayknife. His fingers trembled as he held it near the old marker beside the path. The hilt warmed. The vibration came too quickly, too strongly. He felt movement running through the stone, a heavy rhythm that crossed and crossed again. The impression filled his head until he could not tell which way the slope lay.

He stumbled. His knee struck rock.

The knife told him nothing about Father. It did not know where he was. It did not know what the river had taken. It only held a trace of movement through the marker, stronger than the rain and louder than Philip's own thoughts.

He dropped the knife into the mud and covered his ears, though there was no sound.

The sensation faded. His stomach rolled. He put the dagger away and pressed both hands to the ground. The earth was real. It sloped down toward the stream. The bridge was uphill.

Philip started climbing back.

The slope was steep and slick. He tested each root before trusting it. A rope of harness webbing dangled from above, but he could not see what it was attached to. He did not grab it until he had checked the line, found the iron ring, and felt the stone around it hold under his weight.

Then he climbed.

By the time he reached the bridge approach, the stretcher had shifted behind the rooted abutment. He could see the canvas through the rain, but not Father's face. The harness line still held. The bank had broken away between them.

Philip crawled to the edge and called his father's name.

No answer came.

Rain blurred the bridge and the trees. The stream rose below him. Somewhere under the stone, the roots creaked.

Philip could not see Father.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Under the Rooted Bridge

The storm made the bridge sound alive.

Water ran through its joints and drummed on its stones. Wind pushed at the old masonry, though the bridge had endured weather before Philip's grandparents had been born. It had been built by people who expected roads to matter forever. The people who had stopped repairing it had probably expected something else to last forever instead.

Philip called Father's name again. The rain took it apart before it reached the far side of the abutment.

He lowered himself to his stomach and peered over the broken bank. Mud slid beneath his elbows. Below, the stream had swollen into a brown rush, carrying twigs and a piece of fence rail. He could see the stretcher's canvas caught behind the roots, but the bridge stones hid most of it.

"Father!"

"He cannot hear you over the water," Filroy said.

Philip turned. The fox had appeared from beneath the bridge, fur slick and dark with rain. A cut crossed one ear. He looked from Philip to the stream, then along the bridge's underside.

"You found somewhere dry?"

"I found somewhere less wet. It is not the same thing." Filroy shook water from his whiskers. "The stretcher is below us. The roots hold it. We need to go around."

Philip looked toward the south road. It sloped away between trees, faintly visible through sheets of rain. They could go downhill, reach the road, and search from the

stream's lower bank. It was the easier path. It was also the way that led away from the stretcher.

He tested the harness line at the iron ring. It remained taut. The stone around the ring had cracked, but the roots had taken some of the strain. He could not see the line's lower end.

"Can you get under the bridge?"

"I already did."

"Can you show me?"

Filroy's ears tipped forward. "That is a different question."

Philip nodded. "Then show me."

He left the wayknife sheathed. The path Filroy chose ran behind the bridge's upper stones, away from the soft lip of the bank. Philip moved slowly, feeling each rise and fall through his knees. The rain had loosened the soil, and a single careless step could put him where the stream was strongest.

They circled the abutment on the uphill side, where the earth still held beneath a tangle of roots. Filroy moved ahead, choosing a narrow path between stones. Philip followed on hands and knees. Twice he stopped to test the ground with a branch before putting his weight on it. The branch found one pocket of mud deep enough to swallow his arm to the elbow. He withdrew it slowly, unwilling to discover whether his shoulder could be swallowed next.

At the far end of the abutment, the roots formed a low arch above a shelf of stone. The stretcher lay beneath it, tilted but caught between two thick roots. Father was still tied in. His face had turned toward the stone, and his coat was soaked through at the shoulders.

"Father." Philip crawled to him. "Can you hear me?"

Father's eyes opened. They moved without settling.

"Where—"

"Under the bridge. You're caught against the roots. Don't try to sit up."

Father tried anyway. Pain tightened his face; one hand clutched the canvas.

"Stop," Philip said. "The stretcher is held. I'm here."

The words came out too loudly. Philip lowered his voice. "I'm here."

Father blinked at him. "Philip?"

"Yes."

"The wagon?"

"Gone."

"Horses?"

"Gone too."

Father shut his eyes. Philip could not tell whether the answers had reached him or only passed close. He felt for Father's pulse at the wrist. It was fast but there. He checked the cut at the hairline. The rain had washed away most of the blood, and the wound was still open. Father's breathing was shallow, uneven, but no longer lost in the storm.

"His leg is worse," Philip said.

"The bank shifted the stretcher," Filroy answered. "The lower end struck the stone."

Philip pushed wet canvas aside. Father's trouser leg was torn below the knee. The lower leg had swollen badly; the shape beneath the skin looked wrong. Philip did not try to straighten it. He had seen a broken bone once, years ago, when a carter had fallen from a wagon. It had looked wrong then too, and the healer had told everyone to stop touching it.

"I need to get him off the stretcher without moving that leg."

The stretcher's front pole had split lengthwise. The canvas held, but one corner had slipped below the root arch. Philip could see the harness line running past the broken bank and disappearing into rain. He did not know whether the line held the frame or only kept it from being swept away. He pressed a hand against the stone and listened to the water. The stream had risen almost to the lower shelf.

"We need him moved before the water gets higher," he said.

"The water has been rising," Filroy said. "It may rise more."

Philip looked at the stretcher. "Can you get around behind it?"

"I can."

"Can you push the frame toward me?"

"A little."

"I'll take the other end."

"Then do not pull until I tell you."

"You need more than two hands," Filroy said.

Philip looked at the fox. "I know."

It was the first time he had said it without trying to make the words smaller.

They waited until the worst of the rain passed. Filroy found a section of canvas that could be folded beneath Father's shoulders. Philip freed the stretcher lashings one at a time, keeping the injured leg supported by the frame. He had no proper splint, only two straight pieces of wagon slat and strips of cloth. He laid the slats along either side of the leg, padded them with folded canvas, then tied the cloth above and below the swollen part. He left enough slack that Father's foot did not change color. The knots were not pretty, but they held.

"Too tight?" he asked.

Father did not answer.

"I think he is asleep," Filroy said.

Philip stopped twice to check Father's foot and once to rest his hand. The cloth strips pulled awkwardly against his bruised knuckles. He used the heel of his palm wherever he could and tightened each knot a little at a time. When he finished, he traced the edge of the splint with two fingers, making sure it did not press into the swelling.

"He was awake a moment ago."

"People do that when they are hurt."

Philip checked the cloth again. "I'll loosen it if it swells more."

"A sound plan."

They shifted Father beneath the root arch, onto a dry patch above the stream's rising edge. Philip folded the coat

around him and tucked the surviving blanket close. The wind could still reach them, but the stones blocked most of the rain. He spread the canvas over the gap between the roots and a fallen beam, making a low roof that dripped steadily at one corner.

The work emptied his arms. When it was done, Philip sat with his back against the stone and could not immediately make himself stand again. His head throbbed where it had struck the slope. His hand pulsed beneath its wrap.

Filroy sat across from him, grooming one wet paw. "You did not follow the road."

"I couldn't leave him."

"That is not the same as being unable to."

Philip watched the stream slip beneath the bridge. "I thought about it."

"Naturally."

"I thought if I found help, I could come back."

"Perhaps. The river is rising. Perhaps not." Filroy licked the rain from his paw. "Thinking of the easier path does not mean you chose it."

Philip let his head rest against the stone. For a while the only conversation was the weather passing over them. He slept in short stretches, waking each time Father shifted or the bridge groaned.

Near dawn, Father opened his eyes and kept them open.

For a while Father only watched the water below the arch. Philip was half asleep, but the change in his breathing woke him. Father's eyes tracked the stream, then the roots above them, then Philip's face. Recognition came slowly.

"You came back," Father said.

"I never left."

Father closed his eyes. "Good."

"How long?" he asked.

"Since the storm?" Philip leaned close. "Most of the night."

Father looked at the splint. "You did that?"

"I used what I had. It might need a healer."

"It does." Father swallowed. His voice was clearer, though he still sounded exhausted. "We need Malcore."

"We're going there."

"The Road Office. Aro. The markers."

Philip held his gaze. "You're going to tell me why."

Father's eyes closed once, then opened again. "Yes."

The bridge dripped into the stream. Morning had begun beyond the roots, but Philip stayed close enough to hear.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Father's Road

Father woke with the dawn and spoke before Philip could ask if he was ready.

"Aro saw giant tracks at a marker north of here," he said. "Not just a trail through the woods. The waystone was carrying the pattern."

Philip sat on the stone shelf with the wayknife across his knees. He had wiped mud from its handle, but grit still clung to the grooves. "You knew before we left Hazelwood."

"I knew there was a warning. I did not know the whole route."

"You knew enough to change our trip."

Father breathed in carefully. The movement tugged at the bandage around his ribs. "Yes."

Philip waited. He had learned that if he filled the silence, Father could hide inside it.

"Aro and I agreed to meet in Malcore," Father continued. "He would report what he saw. I would bring the wayknife and show the Road Office the older markers. There is an old road east of the city that may lead toward a place called Stillstone Hollow."

"May?"

"The old maps disagree. Some say the road ended at the farms. Others show it continuing east."

"And the giant?"

"Aro thought it might be following the old road. We needed to find out whether the markers supported that."

"You were going to tell me any of this?"

Father looked down at his hands. "I meant to give you the knife when we reached Malcore. I planned to tell you about the Slayers. About the roads. I thought we would have time to explain it properly."

"You could have told me before we left."

"I could have."

"You told me we were going because we needed a change of scene."

"That was true too."

"It wasn't the reason."

"No."

Philip picked up the wayknife and turned it over. It was a dagger. It fit his hand like a dagger, and the edge would cut skin if he pressed it against his thumb. Somewhere inside the metal was a map that did not know where it was going.

"I thought you were trying to make me into a Slayer," Philip said.

"I wasn't."

"Then what were you trying to do?"

Father's mouth opened. He closed it and began again. "I wanted you to know what I knew. I did not want the old life to decide yours."

"You kept it from me so it wouldn't decide for me."

"Yes."

"That doesn't make sense."

"I know."

The words had no defense in them. Philip found that more difficult than an argument. He had prepared to be told that Father had done what he thought best. Father had said that already, in other ways. This time he only admitted the damage.

Filroy came to the shelter carrying a small, wet bundle of leaves in his mouth. He dropped it beside the cup. "The storm moved a branch across the path. The path will remain there until someone moves it. I cannot say the same for the stream."

"You found food?" Philip asked.

"I found leaves."

"That's not food."

"For me it is a message that there are still plants."

Philip set the leaves aside. He had no appetite for messages. His stomach had gone quiet in the way it did when hunger lasted too long.

Father watched him. "There's more."

Philip rested his arms on his knees. "Tell me."

"The Slayers used those roads for more than travel. We found creatures by reading where they had gone. Sometimes we moved markers to guide them toward a hunt. Sometimes we used the road to get people out of the way."

"You used the marks to send them somewhere."

"We used the roads. The marks only told us what had happened. The choice was ours."

"Was that why the Slayers ended?"

"Partly. The war ended. We had saved people. We had also made choices for towns that did not always want our help. Some hunters thought the danger justified whatever worked. Others thought that was how a protector became another kind of threat."

"Which side were you on?"

Father took a long time to answer. "At the beginning, I thought a road was a tool. If the marker showed where a creature had gone, we could get people out of the way or put hunters where they needed to be."

"And later?"

"Later I saw that the same reading could be used for both. The marker did not know whether we were clearing a road or setting a trap. We did."

"Did you ever move danger without telling the people near it?"

Father's thumb pressed into his palm. "Yes."

"Did they ever find out?"

"I don't know."

Philip looked toward the bridge entrance. Filroy had returned to the stream's edge, keeping watch. Aro's tracks

were still in the wet ground above them. The road held all kinds of records. None of them recorded what a person had chosen not to say.

Father's gaze went to the storm-dark entrance. "I believed I could tell the difference each time."

Philip waited.

"I was not always right."

Father rubbed the heel of his hand against his brow. The bandage shifted, and Philip reached to fix it. Father let him. "We once moved a marker to draw a beast toward an empty quarry. It was meant to keep it away from a village. The beast turned before it reached the quarry. We got the village out in time, but we had not warned them what was coming."

"You could have warned them."

"Yes."

"Why didn't you?"

"We thought we had control of the route. We thought telling them would make them panic."

"Did it?"

"The creature turned. The people saw it. They moved."

Philip folded the edge of the blanket. "You decided what they needed to know."

Father looked at him. "I did."

The answer made the lesson of the road feel less distant. Father had not only hidden the current danger. He had learned to call withholding information protection long before Philip was old enough to question it.

"Why leave?" Philip asked.

Father shifted, then stopped when his leg moved. Philip put a hand out, but Father raised his palm to keep him from touching the splint.

"I was away when your mother died," he said. "The raid came while I was with the Slayers. I came home after. By then there was nothing I could change."

Philip had known the fact of her death for as long as he could remember, though no one had ever sat him down and

given it a shape. He knew she had died in the orc raid. He knew Father had been away. He did not know where the Slayers had been or how long Father had taken to get home, and he did not ask for every detail at once.

"Did you hear about the raid before you came back?"

"I heard after it had happened." Father looked down at the blanket. "I was too far away to return in time."

"Did you think you could have stopped it?"

"For a long time."

"Could you?"

Father looked at him. "I don't know. I was not there. That is the part I cannot answer."

Philip wanted a cleaner answer. He wanted an answer that placed blame somewhere he could point to, or lifted it away. Father had neither. The silence around his mother had never been empty; it had been full of things neither of them knew how to say.

Philip knew she had died. He knew there had been an orc raid. He had not known Father was away because of the Slayers. In the stories of his childhood she had been a name at the edge of photographs, a woman whose shawl Father kept folded in the top drawer. Philip had built no picture of the day she died. Now the empty place had a road leading away from it.

"You think it was your fault."

"I think I was not there."

"That isn't the same thing."

"No." Father pressed his thumb into his palm. "It still mattered."

Philip had wanted to ask why Father had chosen the Slayers over his family. The question arrived sharp and ready. Then he saw the way Father held himself still, as if he were bracing against a second injury. Philip could ask later. Or not. The answer would not bring his mother back or make Father's absence smaller.

"You didn't tell me because you thought the old work would take me away too?"

"I thought if I made you strong enough, nothing would."

"Strong enough to fight."

"That was what I understood."

"And if I had just stayed in the shop?"

"I hoped you would." Father looked at the knife between them. "I wanted you to have the choice I did not give myself. But I kept the truth from you while I waited for you to make it."

Philip looked at the knife's grooves. "You keep wanting me to be prepared, but you don't tell me what for."

"I know."

"I can't help you if you hide the part that matters."

"I know."

"You have to let me decide what I can carry."

Father met his eyes. "I will try."

"And if the Road Office says the old route is too dangerous?"

"We listen to what they know."

"And if they're wrong?"

"We tell them what we saw."

"Even if they don't believe us?"

Father looked toward the knife. "Then we find someone who will check."

It was the first time Father had described a plan that did not depend on Philip obeying him. It was also only a plan for the next few hours. Philip would take that much.

It was not an apology. It was not enough. It was more than he had said before.

They agreed to move after Philip had rested and the stream began to fall. Father would tell him what he remembered about the route, and Philip would tell Father what he saw, even if he was unsure. Filroy would choose the dry ground when the trail split. No one promised the route would be safe.

While Philip folded the blanket, Filroy found a set of boot prints in the soft earth above the bridge. They were spaced evenly, and one heel had left a half-moon nick in the mud.

"Aro?" Philip asked.

"I know one person who walks as if every footprint is an introduction," Father said.

The prints came from the south road. They were fresh enough that rain had not filled them.

Father looked at Philip. "He is catching up."

Philip tucked the wayknife into his belt. "Then we should hear what he knows."

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The False Signal

Aro found them in the afternoon where the road climbed above the stream.

Philip heard him before he saw him: the scrape of a boot on loose stone, followed by a pause that lasted long enough to mean someone was listening. Philip lifted one hand to stop Aro and Filroy. The stretcher rested against a low bank. Father was asleep. The brush ahead hid the path around the bend.

"Who is it?" Philip called.

"Aro Silvet."

"How do I know?"

"You sold me twelve arrows."

"That proves you were at the shop."

"It proves I paid for the arrows. I have the receipt if you want to audit me."

Philip glanced at Filroy. The fox's ears were turned toward the voice. "It sounds like him."

"It sounds like someone who wants us to think it sounds like him," Filroy said.

Philip kept his hand raised. "Come around slowly."

He came through the trees without his hide hood, carrying his bow in one hand and a short pack over his shoulder. The Alcrog coat was dark with rain. One of its folded wings had caught on a branch and hung loose behind him.

"You look worse than the road," he said.

"The road has had fewer chances to sleep," Philip replied.

Aro's eyebrows lifted. "You've been talking to the fox."

"I can hear you," Filroy said from the rock beside the stretcher.

"I assumed." Aro put down his pack. "I'm glad you're alive. Both of you."

He unbuckled the pack and took out a small bundle of food, a flask, and a dry strip of cloth. When Philip admitted they had almost lost the stretcher in the swamp, Aro gave Father a few mouthfuls of water, then handed the rest to Philip.

"We don't need to finish it now," Aro said. "We need enough for the next stretch."

Philip stared at the bread. "How long have you been carrying this?"

"Since yesterday."

"You were ahead of us."

"I was on the road. You were in the forest."

"You could have met us sooner."

"I could have taken the low track and missed you entirely." Aro folded the empty wrapping. "I reached the Shelf Road after the wagon went over. I found the wreck and the tracks leading south. The stretcher had left a line through the mud that was easier to follow than any road marker. I followed it as far as the swamp. After that, I had to wait for the water to fall."

"You went back to the wreck?" Father asked.

"I checked the wagon first. It was burning. I couldn't climb down safely, and I saw the trail you'd taken."

"You could have reached us sooner if you'd gone through the low ground."

"The low ground was under water."

Father closed his eyes. "Right."

Aro looked at Philip. "I should have come to the wreck sooner."

"You wouldn't have known we were there."

"I knew someone had survived. There were prints."

"We had already gone." Philip looked at the bread and the flask. "You came when you could."

Aro nodded, though the answer did not seem to absolve him. He was used to arriving at a problem before it got worse. This one had changed shape while he was on the road.

He covered his relief by examining the splint and the stretcher. He asked how Father had been hurt, how long they had been on the road, what water they had found, and whether the storm had damaged the old bridge. He listened to the answers without interrupting.

When he learned that Father could not walk, Aro looked toward the south. "We can move faster if we leave the stretcher and carry him between us."

"No," Philip said.

Aro glanced at him. "You have a better plan?"

"The stretcher keeps his leg still. Carrying him would pull it around."

"The south road will take another day at this pace."

"Then we'll take another day."

The answer had come too quickly. Philip looked at Father. The old version of him would have waited for Father to agree or had to prove he deserved to speak. He tried again.

"I don't know if the stretcher can hold up that long," he said. "But we can repair the frame and check the lashings. If the road gets worse, we stop."

Father nodded once. "That's sound."

Aro looked between them, then accepted the point. "Very well. We'll reinforce it."

Before they lifted the stretcher, Aro asked Philip to show him the worst of the frame. Philip showed him the split pole and the canvas seam that had begun to fray. Aro did not replace the whole frame. He added one brace, then let Philip test it. The repair held under the weight of the stretcher, but Philip kept his hand on the lashing until the first few steps were done.

They worked together. Aro cut a straight branch from a fallen limb and lashed it beneath the stretcher's cracked side rail. Philip checked the knots. Filroy inspected the nearby

ground and disliked the way the slope narrowed before the next marker. Father watched, offering directions in short bursts when the pain allowed.

At the marker, Aro stopped.

It was a squat post of dark stone with a band of worked iron around its middle. The band had been bent outward, but the face remained intact. Aro looked at the wayknife at Philip's belt. "May I?"

Philip hesitated, then unfastened the sheath and handed it over. Aro brought the blade within reach of the iron. The hilt warmed. A pulse traveled along the blade, and Aro's wrist tipped toward the south road.

"The strongest trace runs straight to Malcore," Aro said.

He returned the wayknife. Philip took it, then looked at the ground beneath the marker. Broad impressions crossed the road and angled toward the river. The deepest had filled with water; a branch lay crushed at its edge. "It doesn't look straight."

Aro glanced back. "The marker is clear."

"The trace is strong. That doesn't mean it's the old road."

"It is a direction."

"It might be the giant."

Aro rested one hand on the marker. "That is what we are trying to follow."

"Then why does it point toward the city?"

"Because the city is south."

"Or because the giant walked there."

For a moment the three of them stood around the marker, listening to the rainwater drip from the trees. Aro's confidence had not disappeared, but it had become something he was holding rather than something that held him.

"The old route bent east," Father said. "There was a causeway before the farms expanded."

"You remember it?"

"I remember a map. I have not walked it in years."

Aro looked at the road, then at the bent iron. “The Road Office will need more than a boy’s guess.”

“It’s an observation,” Philip said. “I don’t know where it goes yet.”

His fingers found the knife’s hilt. He wanted to take it out, test the marker himself, and prove he had heard what he heard. He also remembered the slope spinning beneath the storm and the way the echo had filled his head until he could not tell which way was up.

He left it sheathed.

“We can compare the next marker,” he said. “And look at the tracks between them. If they match, that gives us more to work with.”

Aro studied him. “You are asking me to wait.”

“I’m asking us to check.”

Father shifted under the blanket. “Philip is right about the reading. It tells us what passed most often. It does not say why.”

Aro’s jaw tightened. “I know what a wayknife does.”

“Then you know it could be wrong for the question we’re asking.”

The sentence landed harder than Philip meant it to. Father turned his face away. Aro looked back at the marker.

“We will compare the next one,” Aro said at last. “Then we take the route that gets your father medical care.”

“Agreed.”

They continued south at a careful pace. The next marker stood beside a drainage cut, nearly hidden beneath fern. Its iron band had rusted through on one side. Aro examined it without using the wayknife. Philip kept the blade sheathed; the bent iron and rust might only confuse the trace.

They found deep impressions pressed into the earth between the posts. The tracks crossed the road, then angled toward the river. One had filled with water. A branch lay crushed beneath a print broader than Philip’s shoulders.

"It is moving along the ridge," Filroy said. "The ground is higher there."

Aro looked north, toward the dark line of the river. "If it reaches the river road, it will be headed for Malcore."

"Or following the dry ground," Philip said.

"Either way, the city is in its path."

No one had an answer that made the road less dangerous. Father's stretcher creaked when Aro and Philip lifted it over the drainage cut. The rain softened to a mist, but the sky remained low and gray. Somewhere beyond the ridge, a deep, slow impact shuddered through the ground.

The giant was moving again.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The North Giant

They reached the ridge before the giant did.

The old road climbed between two outcrops and bent east. From the top, Philip could see the river below, brown and broad beneath the clouded sky. Beyond it lay the south road to Malcore. A line of broken trees marked the giant's passage along the slope, sometimes hidden by the pines, sometimes visible as a raw strip of earth.

Filroy found a hollow between the rocks where the stretcher could be set down. A low shelf overhung it, enough to keep the worst of the drizzle off Father. The ridge offered a view of the trail below, but the stones screened them from the open ground.

"We wait here," Aro said. He crouched beside the rock and eased his bow from his shoulder.

"For what?" Philip asked.

"To see where it goes."

"You said the city is in its path."

"I said the city may be." Aro checked the bowstring for water. "We need to know what it does when the route is open."

"And if it turns toward us?"

"Then we leave."

"With Father on the stretcher?"

Aro did not answer immediately. His eyes went to the frame, then the narrow ledge above the river. "Then we hope it does not."

It was not much of a plan, but at least it admitted the part that was missing.

Philip helped Aro ease the stretcher into the hollow. They had to lift it over a lip of stone, and Philip's injured hand began to shake before they had cleared it. He kept his eyes on the frame instead of Father's leg. The leg was not straight in the way Philip wished it were, and looking did not improve it.

Filroy circled the hollow twice. He sniffed the wind, then the ground, then the narrow gap between two rocks. "If we need to leave, go through there. It opens on the back side of the ridge."

"Can we get Father through?"

"Not quickly."

"Can we get him through at all?"

Filroy stared at the stretcher. "If you do not insist on carrying the rocks too."

Philip crouched and checked the canvas ties. "We'll see if we need to."

He wanted to ask why Filroy had stayed with them. The fox had not promised to help in a fight, and Philip would not have asked him to. He was a small animal with a territory to protect and no reason to be crushed because a human boy was afraid. Philip decided not to ask for a promise he had no right to expect.

They pulled the stretcher deeper beneath the rock shelf. Philip tucked the canvas around Father and checked the splint. The swelling had not worsened, though Father's face was pale and damp. He was awake, following the sound of their voices.

"It's coming from the north," Father said.

"We can see the corridor," Philip replied.

"No. Listen."

The ridge carried sound strangely. The river's rush faded. Rain tapped the leaves. Then the ground gave a low, uneven shudder. Another followed after several breaths.

The giant appeared below the ridge, moving between the trees.

Its approach announced itself in the animals first. A line of birds lifted from the pines. A hare darted across the exposed

slope, then stopped at the rocks below them, confused by the scent of human sweat and blood. It veered away. The giant's weight came after: a dull thump, a pause, then another. Philip felt each one through his knees.

He counted without meaning to. Four impacts crossed the hollow. A fifth came closer than the others. The giant was not walking straight toward them; the sound moved along the ridge below, rising and falling with the slope.

In daylight, Philip could see more than he had from the hill. The giant's head was stone-gray and blunt, fissured like a boulder left through too many winters. A heavy cloak of hide and woven branches covered its shoulders. It leaned forward as it walked, one hand touching tree trunks or rocks as if testing the ground. Its steps were slow, but each one pressed the soil into a dark hollow.

It reached a patch of brush near a leaning pine and stopped. A fox den opened at the base of the tree. A smaller fox darted from the roots and vanished into the rocks.

The giant turned its head toward the den. Philip's breath caught. Its arm lifted.

Then it lowered the arm and stepped around the tree.

"It saw the den," Philip whispered.

"It saw the tree," Aro said. He had his bow raised, an arrow set against the string. "We don't know what it saw."

The giant continued along the ridge. Its path angled away from the river's flooded edge, toward higher ground. When the trail dipped into a wet hollow, it stopped, shifted its weight, and climbed the stony rise instead.

"It keeps to the dry ground," Filroy said.

"It may simply be easier to walk there," Aro murmured.

"Those can both be true," Philip said.

Father's hand closed around the canvas. "The old route followed the basalt rise."

Philip looked at him. "To Stillstone Hollow?"

"I don't know. The map showed an eastward road. There was a shelter somewhere beyond the farms."

Aro's bow remained drawn. "The route bends toward the city wall."

"At the next low ground," Father said. "It would have had to turn east before the farms."

The giant reached the dip where the ridge narrowed. Aro's pack shifted against the stone beside him. A metal clasp struck the rock with a bright clink.

The giant stopped.

Its head swung toward the sound. Its shoulders turned. One hand grasped a dead pine limb lying across the trail and lifted it. The limb was thicker than a wagon axle. The giant swept it across the slope.

The branch struck the rocks beneath their shelf. Stone chips burst upward. Aro ducked. Philip threw himself over Father's stretcher. Filroy vanished into a crack in the rock. The limb scraped the shelf's edge, then fell down the ridge and crashed through the trees.

No one moved.

The hand that held the branch had dropped to its side. The giant's fingers flexed once. One of its shoulders rose and fell beneath the rough covering. Philip wondered if it was breathing hard. He could hear his own breath too loudly to tell.

The giant stood facing them. Its head tilted, listening. It did not roar or call. The silence gave Philip no clue whether it was angry, frightened, or only trying to find the noise.

Philip kept his hand over Father's shoulder. His palm felt Father's body rise and fall beneath the blanket. The giant's gaze passed over the rocks. It could not see into the hollow, or perhaps it did and could not tell what the hollow contained.

After a long moment, it turned away. It set one foot carefully on the dry rise and continued east.

Aro lowered the bow only after the giant disappeared behind the trees.

"That thing is dangerous," he said.

"Yes," Philip said.

"It can break the wall."

"Yes."

"And you think it is looking for a place to sleep?"

"I think it avoids the water and keeps choosing the higher ground. I don't know why."

Aro's expression tightened, but not with anger. "You are right to leave room for what we don't know."

It was not agreement. It was a first step toward it.

"If it reaches the city, we may not get another chance," Aro said.

"If it turns east, we may not need one," Philip replied.

"And if it doesn't?"

"Then we'll know more than we know now."

Aro looked at him. "That is not enough to protect a city."

"It's enough to decide what we check next."

Father pointed with two fingers toward a low stone half-hidden beneath the roots at the east end of the ridge. "That marker is older than the road. If it is intact, it may show the turn."

Philip looked at the iron band on his knife. He could feel a faint warmth, though he had not drawn it. The giant's passage had disturbed the markers all around them. He wanted to know what the stone held. His head still swam from the storm, and the ledge had just been struck by a tree limb.

"We'll check it after we're off this ridge," he said.

Aro glanced at him. "Not now?"

"Not while we're hiding from the thing that made the ground shake."

Father let out a breath that might have been the beginning of a laugh, though it hurt him. "A sensible delay."

The ridge below them was empty. The old marker remained where it had stood, half buried and waiting. Philip had begun to understand that waiting could be a decision too.

CHAPTER TWENTY

The Old Causeway

They left the ridge after the giant's steps had faded.

They waited another hour before moving. Philip counted the time by the light creeping across the basalt and by Father's short periods of wakefulness. Twice Father asked where they were. Once he asked for the wagon. Philip answered both questions without correcting him sharply. The healer in Malcore would know more than any of them, but the city was still a distance away.

While they waited, Aro marked their position on the damaged map. His pencil broke through the paper where the map had been wet. He sharpened it with his knife and tried again.

"You said the old road passed behind farms," Philip said. "How did the farms get there?"

"The city grew," Father replied. "The road was no longer maintained. People built close to the wall. The land became useful for crops and storage."

"Did nobody notice the turn disappeared?"

"They noticed the road had stopped being used. That is not the same as noticing where it went."

Philip looked east, where the trees crowded together above the slope. A road could disappear by being covered, fenced, or simply forgotten by people who had never needed it. None of those things required anyone to decide to erase it.

The track ran east along the basalt rise. Philip and Aro carried the stretcher while Filroy moved ahead, checking the path. Father stayed conscious for most of the descent, though he spoke only when the ground forced them to stop. The rain

had eased. Water dripped from branches and gathered in shallow pools along the old stones.

At the first marker, Father asked them to set the stretcher down.

It was a narrow slab wedged between two rocks, its face worn almost smooth. A strip of iron had been sunk into its side. The iron was cracked near the top, leaving a dark seam that ran down to the stone's base.

"I remember this," Father said. "There used to be a cut here. The road divided: west toward the river, east along the rise."

"Which way did the old road go?" Philip asked.

"Both, at different points. A road can be more than one line."

"The map you had only showed one."

"It was a poor map."

"Why keep it?"

"It was the one I had."

Philip considered this. People often kept bad things because they were the things available. There were worse reasons for a map, though not many.

He took the wayknife from his belt. The stone's iron band was intact enough to answer. He crouched close and held the hilt within a hand's width of the marker.

Warmth spread into his palm. A pulse moved through the blade, faint but steady. He felt two directions at once: one heavy and recent, angling down toward the river; another lighter, a repeated rhythm running east along the rise. The impressions did not become pictures. They were only the sense of feet and wheels passing over ground, one after another, the older rhythm nearly lost beneath the newer one.

Philip pulled the knife away.

The eastward trace lingered in his balance. His head tilted as if the world had shifted a finger's width. He planted his hand on the marker and waited for the sensation to pass.

"What did you find?" Aro asked.

"Two lines. The stronger one goes down toward the river. The lighter one goes east."

"The giant's track is stronger."

"I think so. It feels heavier. The other one is more regular."

Father nodded. "Carts and people. The old causeway."

"How old?"

"Old enough that the road office stopped maintaining it."

Filroy sniffed the ground. "The east ground stays dry past the next rise. I used it before the trees fell."

Philip looked from one to the other. The marker offered a direction. Father offered a memory. Filroy offered the ground beneath their feet. None of those answers was enough alone, but together they seemed to point toward the same place.

They continued to the next marker. It had fallen face-down in the leaf litter. Father recognized the iron fitting, but its stone had broken into three pieces. Philip did not test it. The damage made the reading uncertain, and he had already paid for one reading with a spinning head.

At the third marker, the old road crossed a shallow wash. The post stood upright, its iron band rusted but unbroken. Aro offered Philip the knife. Philip's balance still felt a little wrong from the first reading.

"I want to compare it," Philip said. "But I don't trust my head enough to know what I'm feeling."

"A good reason to wait," Aro said.

Father pointed toward the wash. "Markers do not lie. People ask them the wrong question."

"Then I need to ask the ground first." Philip studied the broad prints pressed into the mud below the post. They led toward the wash, where the bank had slumped under the weight, but there was no matching print on the far side. Higher up, old wheel ruts ran along the embankment and disappeared east beneath the thorn. "The giant went down toward the water. The old road stays on the rise."

"The bank is too soft to cross," Filroy said.

"And the smaller trace could be old carts," Philip said. "Or something else."

"The causeway," Father said. "It used to run east behind the farms. Before the fields were fenced."

They followed the higher ground. In places, stone blocks showed under moss. The road had not vanished so much as been covered by everything that had grown after people stopped tending it. A low embankment rose above the wash and curved east, then disappeared beneath thorn and sapling.

From the top, they could see the outer farms of Malcore. Smoke rose from the city beyond them, and the wall stood gray beneath the cloud. The old road led behind a line of fields toward a gate or barrier hidden by trees.

The giant's tracks crossed the lower approach and continued south. At the embankment, the broad prints turned. One pressed deep beside a stone post. Another angled along the rise, toward the overgrown fields.

"It tried to turn here," Philip said.

"Or it stepped around the mud," Aro answered.

"That's possible." Philip looked at the slope, the water below, and the exposed rock ahead. "We need to see what's past the farms."

Father lifted his head. "If the old turn is there, it may lead to Stillstone Hollow."

"May," Philip said.

Father met his eyes. "May."

The route narrowed before the camp. Aro and Philip lifted the stretcher over a fallen stone while Filroy found a way around the bramble. Father woke when they lowered him. He asked if the road had turned east.

"We think it did," Philip said. "The ground and the traces agree so far."

"You think?"

"We haven't seen where it goes yet."

Father watched him for a moment, then let his head rest against the blanket. "Good."

Philip had expected his father to want a stronger answer. The fact that Father did not ask him to pretend felt like a small change.

They could not cross the bramble with the stretcher before dark. Aro chose a sheltered hollow on the south side of the embankment, with a clear view of the city and the track. They would rest there, then reach Malcore at first light. Philip put the wayknife away. The eastward trace was not a promise. But for the first time, the old road was more than a line on a torn map.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Aro's Arrows

Aro made a small fire from dry twigs beneath an overhang. The flame was modest and smoky, but it warmed Philip's hands. The city wall showed above the trees. Beyond it, a tower caught the last light and held it longer than the roofs around it.

Father lay with his head on the folded blanket. He had spoken little since they stopped. His eyes were open, though Philip could tell he was using most of his strength to remain awake.

Aro checked the arrows in his quiver. All twelve remained. Philip remembered wrapping them in brown paper at the shop. He wondered if Aro had checked each one before putting them away. It seemed likely. Aro checked everything else.

"You said your friend would have been irritated if you made too much of him," Philip said.

Aro kept his eyes on the fletching. "He would."

"You tell the story as if it explains what you should do."

"Does it?"

"I don't know. He killed an Alcrog and died anyway."

Aro set the arrow down. "He saved me. The beast had me pinned. If he had not gone inside it, I would have died."

He picked up the arrow again, then set it down in precisely the same place. "We had been hunting the Alcrog for two days. It had taken a mule and damaged a bridge. The village wanted it dead. We found its lair before dawn, but the wind changed while we were setting the line. I told him to wait until the wind turned back."

"Did it?"

"No. The Alcrog came down first. It went for me because I was closest. Philip had a clear path to the rocks. He came back."

"You told him not to?"

"I shouted it. He heard me." Aro rubbed his thumb over a nick in the arrow's shaft. "The story makes it sound like he had a plan. He had a knife and a moment. That was all."

"Would you have done the same?"

"I don't know." Aro looked toward the dark wall. "I have spent years telling myself I would."

"Then it mattered."

"Yes."

"But he didn't survive."

"No."

Philip moved a small stick into the fire. "When you said I looked like a warrior, I thought you meant I should be like him."

"I said it because I saw something familiar in you. Not the fighting. The attention. You counted those arrows twice and still knew one had a bent feather."

"I didn't know it was bent until you pointed it out."

"You looked."

"I'm not him."

Aro leaned back against the stone. "No. You are not."

There was no argument in his voice, but Philip had heard the hesitation before the answer. Aro's dead friend lived in the space between what a person had done and what someone else wanted his story to mean.

"Did he want to be a Slayer?" Philip asked.

"He wanted to be useful. That is a dangerous desire. It can make a person think every risk is his to take."

"Did he think that?"

"Sometimes." Aro looked into the fire. "He was brave. He was also stubborn. I told the story like the first quality had made the second one wise."

Philip glanced at the bow beside Aro. "And if the giant reaches the wall?"

Aro did not answer right away. He took an arrow from the quiver, checked its point, then put it back. "If it threatens the gate, I will shoot."

"Even if it's trying to get somewhere?"

"A city cannot wait for a theory."

"It has to decide what to do before it knows everything." Philip looked toward the wall. "But it can still wait long enough to check."

"How long?"

"I don't know. Until we see the next turn. Until the roadwarden sees the tracks. Until we find what is behind the farms."

Aro's face had gone tired. The confidence that people praised in him looked less like certainty in the firelight and more like a habit he had learned because other people needed him to choose.

"I will wait for the route evidence," he said. "If the giant comes at the wall, I will not pretend the risk is small."

"Would your friend have waited?" Philip asked.

Aro's face tightened. "I don't know. I never asked him what he would do in a different hunt. I only remember what he did in that one."

"That sounds like a hard thing to remember."

"It is."

Philip looked into the fire. "I don't want you to shoot because you think I'm supposed to be like him."

"I won't." Aro's answer came without delay. "Your name has nothing to do with this."

"I'm not asking you to."

"Good." Aro took a piece of bread from his pack and broke it into three portions. He handed one to Philip, one to Father, and kept the smallest for himself. "Then we agree on more than we did this morning."

Father held his portion but did not eat it at once. “You and I used to argue about which way to turn a creature.”

Aro’s eyes remained on the fire. “We argued about whether the road could keep danger away from a settlement.”

“We used a marker to pull a beast toward an abandoned quarry,” Father said. “The quarry was empty. We believed it was safe.”

“It was,” Aro said.

“Until the beast changed direction.”

“We moved the people in time.”

“Because someone saw it change direction.” Father’s hand tightened around the bread. “The people who lived there did not know we had sent it toward them.”

Aro did not look at him. “We were trying to keep the danger away from the city.”

“We were making a choice for people who had not been asked.”

Philip looked from one man to the other. “Did anyone get hurt?”

“Not that time,” Father said.

“That time,” Aro repeated, softly.

Neither of them added more. Philip understood the argument now. The road could help people move away from danger, or help someone else decide where the danger should go. The marker could not tell the difference.

Philip ate slowly. It was stale and dry. It was also the first proper food he had seen since Hazelwood. His stomach tightened around it, then accepted the next bite.

Father opened his eyes. “Philip.”

“I’m here.”

“You don’t have to prove anything to Aro.”

“I know.”

“Or to me.”

Philip looked at him. The words were careful, as if Father had to pass them through a narrow doorway. “I know that too.”

Father closed his eyes again. Philip could not tell whether he meant it, or whether he was trying to learn how to mean it.

The night grew colder. Aro took the first watch. Philip slept in fits, waking to the fire's collapse and to the distant sound of something moving across the ridge. Each time the ground trembled, Filroy raised his head. The fox did not leave the hollow.

At first light, Malcore's warning bell rang once from behind the wall.

A second bell answered from farther east.

Aro was already on his feet, bow in hand. "It's close."

Philip sat up too quickly. The world swayed, then settled. He pressed his palm to the ground until the dizziness passed.

The bell rang a third time. From the east road, where the outer farms stood between the city and the old causeway, a low vibration moved under the soil.

They had reached the city on the same morning as the giant.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Malcore's Gate

Malcore's outer gate was closed when they reached it.

The wall rose above the road in blocks of pale stone. People had gathered outside: farmers with carts, drovers with pack animals, and families carrying whatever they could lift. A guard stood on the inner parapet calling names and directions. The main gate remained shut while a narrow wicket opened and closed one person at a time.

The line advanced only when the wicket opened. A woman carried a sleeping child wrapped in a rug; an old man held the reins of a donkey that kept trying to eat the rug. A pair of farmers argued over whose cart had been there first. Neither seemed to know what they would do if the other agreed. Beyond them, the road curved east toward the farms. The warning bell had stopped, but people continued to look that way.

The gate staff were not being cruel. They were trying to keep a frightened crowd from pushing through a narrow opening at once. That still left a stretcher outside the wall, and the gate did not care what good reasons a person had.

The crowd had the anxious look of people who had heard a danger was coming but had not yet agreed what kind. Some stared east. Others watched the guards. A child sat on a sack of grain and asked for water. His mother answered that they would find some inside. She said it with the confidence of someone who needed him to stop asking.

Philip and Aro carried Father's stretcher to the side of the gate. Filroy stayed back beneath a cart, out of the crush. His tail brushed the wheel once, then tucked away.

"We need a healer," Philip told the guard at the wicket. "My father has a head injury and a broken leg."

The guard leaned out. "We're taking the injured through. Name and home?"

"Philip. Hazelwood."

"And the fox?"

"He's with me."

"Foxes don't come through the gate."

"He's not going to the healer."

"That was not the part I was worried about."

The guard looked past Philip at the stretcher. A second guard approached from inside, carrying a ring of keys. "The wicket latch is jammed again. We can't open it wide enough for a litter."

"Then use the main gate," someone called from the crowd.

"The main gate is holding the crowd outside," the guard answered. "If we open both, we will have the crowd in two places."

Philip listened to the argument behind him. Aro shifted the stretcher to keep Father's head raised. The canvas had grown damp again, and Father's breath sounded rough. Philip's own legs had begun to shake. He tried to focus on the latch, the iron pin, the groove, and the pressure of the gate against the stone. Problems with visible parts were easier to look at than the ones that could not be fixed with a tool.

Philip studied the wicket. Its iron latch slid into a groove cut into the stone. A narrow pin held the mechanism in place. When the gate shifted under pressure, the pin had slipped sideways and caught against a worn lip. The guard tried to pull it back with the key, but the key's teeth scraped the face of the lock.

"Can I look?" Philip asked.

The guard gave him a doubtful glance. "You know gates?"

"I know when a thing is caught on the wrong side of a groove."

It was a shop answer, not a gate answer. The guard stepped aside anyway.

Philip knelt. The iron pin was bent slightly, but not enough to break. He pressed the wicket inward with one shoulder, relieving the pressure on the latch. The pin shifted. He took the flat end of a small tool from Aro's kit and eased it back along the groove.

"Now pull," he said.

The guard drew the latch. The wicket swung wider.

The guard pulled once more to make sure it would stay open. The pin slid along the groove and stopped before catching. Philip watched it hold under the weight of the door, then stepped aside to let the porters take the stretcher.

"There," Philip said. "It was holding against the stone."

"We have a gatewright," the guard said.

"Then you can tell him it's holding against the stone."

The guard almost smiled. He signaled for two porters, who came through the wicket and helped carry Father into the city. Philip stepped after them. He looked back once.

Filroy had moved from beneath the cart. He stood at the boundary stone, on the outer side of the wall. The fox was watching Philip, not the city.

"I'll come back," Philip said.

"You have somewhere to be," Filroy replied.

Philip followed the stretcher inside.

The infirmary was a long stone building near the gate. The healer and her assistants took Father from them before Philip had finished explaining what had happened. They cut away his trouser leg, checked the splint, and asked how long he had been unconscious. Philip answered what he knew. Aro gave the details Philip did not have.

The healer examined Father's eyes, cleaned the head wound, and pressed along the lower leg. Father woke and cried out when she reached the break. She told him not to move, then ordered a second assistant to bring a proper splint.

The assistants asked Philip to wait outside the curtain while they removed the soaked canvas and checked Father's ribs. He stood in the infirmary passage with his hands empty. Aro went to speak to the gate guards. For the first time since the crash, no one needed Philip to hold a pole, tie a knot, or count breaths. He did not know what to do with his hands.

He washed them at a basin. The water ran pink, then clear. He kept rubbing after the blood was gone, until the healer called his name and told him the skin would not come back cleaner by force.

"Is he going to be all right?" Philip asked.

"He is alive, and he is in the right place," the healer said. "That is what I can promise you now. The bone is broken. His head needs watching. He will not be walking today."

"How long?"

"Longer than you want."

Philip nodded. He had asked because he wanted a number. The healer had given him a truth.

Aro stood near the doorway, still wearing the wet Alcrog hide. "I need to speak to the Road Office."

"They know the giant is coming," the healer said. "The bell has rung."

"Then they need the route evidence."

Philip looked toward the window. Beyond the infirmary yard, the wall blocked the road. Beyond the wall, Filroy was somewhere among the waiting carts.

"I need to talk to the roadwarden too," Philip said.

Aro's gaze shifted toward him. "You're staying with your father."

"He's with the healer. I can help with the road."

"You are hurt."

"So is he. I can still talk."

The healer drew a curtain around Father's bed. "You can talk for a short while. Then you will sit down, drink water, and let me look at that head wound."

Philip agreed. It was not a battle worth having.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

The Road Office

Malcore's Road Office occupied three rooms above the south gatehouse.

The first held maps, ledgers, and a table too large for the room. The second held people trying to use the table at once. The third held the roadwarden, who had placed both hands on a map of the city and was listening to a clerk read the latest bell reports.

The clerk read the reports in a quick, practiced voice. One bell from the east watch. A second from the outer farms. No injuries reported at the wall. Two carts delayed at the north gate. A request for more sandbags at the river culvert. The facts came in without an order that would make them comforting.

The roadwarden waited until the clerk finished, then asked the same question twice: "How certain is the direction?" The first messenger had said south. The second had said southeast. The third had reported the giant had stopped.

"It may have stopped," the clerk said. "Or the watcher lost sight of it."

"Write that," the roadwarden replied. "Do not shorten it to 'stopped.'"

Philip expected the roadwarden to be older. She was a square-shouldered woman with short gray hair and ink on the side of one thumb. Her coat had no ornament except a brass road pin. She looked at Aro, then at Philip, then at the mud and dried blood on both of them.

"You came from the north road?" she asked.

"From the Shelf Road," Aro said. "The giant has been following a route through the forest. We saw it on the ridge."

"And its direction?"

"South."

"Toward the city?"

"Toward the river road."

Philip stepped closer to the map. "It keeps to high ground. At the ridge it avoided the flooded hollow and turned east along the basalt rise."

The roadwarden looked at him. "You saw that?"

"We watched it. We also found old markers along the causeway."

Aro placed the damaged map on the table. "The current marker readings show a strong route south. The old eastward line is weak."

"Then why should we consider it?"

"Because the giant's passage is stronger than the older traffic," Philip said. "The wayknife reads what traveled most. It doesn't tell us where the giant means to go."

The roadwarden's eyes moved to the dagger at his belt. "How many readings did you make?"

"Two. Aro read the marker on the ridge; I read the intact causeway marker. His reading showed a strong route south. At the causeway, I felt that heavy trace over a lighter, more regular one running east."

"And the fallen marker beyond it?"

"It was damaged. I didn't read it."

The roadwarden glanced at Aro. "You agree with that account?"

Aro hesitated. "I agree that the knife cannot tell us why the giant is moving. I believe the city is at risk if we wait too long."

"Those can both be true," the roadwarden said. "We have a wall to protect and people in the outer farms. We also have no clear access to the east service road. The old road is listed as blocked by private land and a failed drainage cut."

"We could inspect it," Philip said.

"A roadworker can inspect it. You need medical attention."

"I'll get it. My father is here with the healer. I can show the roadworker where the stone turn is."

Father's voice came from the doorway. "He should not be sent out again."

Philip turned. The healer had brought Father in on a wheeled cot. His leg was enclosed in a proper splint, his head wrapped cleanly. He looked exhausted, but awake.

"I can speak for myself," Philip said.

The room went quiet. Father closed his eyes briefly.

"You're right," he said. "I'm sorry."

The roadwarden pointed to a chair. "Your father is going back to the infirmary. You may speak with a roadworker for an hour, provided the healer agrees. You will not go beyond the outer farms without an escort."

"That's enough," Philip said.

The roadwarden tapped the map. "The east road crosses a drainage cut. If the cut has failed, a giant cannot pass without making it worse. If it is blocked by fences, the farms will be in its path. I will not order people to clear it based on a faint marker and a boy's impression."

The roadwarden pulled a second map from beneath the first. This one showed the farms by name, with fields and wells marked in red. A black line stopped at the drainage cut. "If the giant turns at the wall, it will enter these fields. If we clear the east road and it does not take it, we may expose the workers without gaining anything."

"If you don't clear it, there won't be a choice," Philip said. "We don't know where it wants to go. We know the turn is blocked, and we know it keeps taking the rise."

"What would you have me do?"

"Send a small group to find out if the road is still there. Move the families away from the fields. Keep the wall ready until we know more."

The roadwarden glanced at Aro. “Would you support that?”

“Yes,” Aro said. “As long as the wall remains prepared.”

“And if the route is blocked?”

“Then I will take the shot if it comes to that.”

The roadwarden nodded once. “That is a plan with a condition. I can work with a condition.”

“It isn’t only the marker,” Philip said. “We saw the giant choose the rise. We found its tracks turning at the old causeway. Filroy knows the dry ground past the farms.”

“The fox?”

“He’s outside the wall.”

The roadwarden considered him. “Bring him to the gate. I will speak to him if he chooses to speak to me.”

“He doesn’t take orders.”

“That may make him easier to interview than some people in this room.”

Aro gave a short, surprised laugh. The roadwarden did not smile, but her eyes softened by a fraction.

“I’ll send a roadworker,” she said. “One hour. If you find a passable route, bring back evidence. If you don’t, the city will prepare the wall.”

Father’s hands tightened on the cot blanket. “The old turn is there. I remember it.”

“You remember a map,” Philip said. “We need to see what is on the ground.”

Father looked at him, then nodded. “Yes.”

The healer turned the cot toward the door. “Now you need rest.”

“I can still help—”

“You can help by staying conscious long enough to heal.”

Father looked ready to argue, then stopped. The cot rolled out of the room.

The roadwarden handed Philip a folded map and a small brass token. “Show the token at the east service gate. The roadworker will meet you there.”

Philip took them. The map showed the current road clearly and the old road as a dotted line that ended where the farms began.

"The missing part is the problem," he said.

"Yes," said the roadwarden. "That is why you have one hour."

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

The Buried Turn

The east service gate stood behind a row of storehouses.

It was narrower than the main gate and opened onto a track bordered by garden walls. A roadworker waited beside it with a shovel over one shoulder and a rolled survey sheet beneath his arm. He introduced himself as Hedd, then looked at Philip's bruised hand and the fresh wrap around his head.

"You're the marker reader?"

"I'm the one who saw the tracks."

"That is not the same thing."

"No."

Hedd seemed satisfied by the answer. He opened the gate and let them through. Aro joined them with his bow. Filroy emerged from the shadow of a cart and crossed the boundary stone without comment.

The old road began as a line of stones beneath grass. It passed behind the last gardens and reached a low field where a wooden barrier had been built across it. Beyond the barrier lay an overgrown lane. A drainage cut split the land in two, its sides lined with old stonework.

The cut was clogged with leaves, branches, and silt. Water had carved a narrow channel beneath the blockage, but the stones remained in place.

Hedd set his shovel against the near bank and leaned on it. The handle sank a little into the soft earth. Philip could see where water had undercut the grass. The old road stones were solid at the top, but the edge of the cut was not.

"If we stand there, it'll give," Philip said.

Hedd shifted back. "You see that from here?"

"The grass is hanging over empty space. There's water under it."

The roadworker tested the ground farther inland. His boot pressed down; the earth held. "Good. We'll approach from this side."

Philip took the branch he had been using as a walking stick and pushed it into the bank. It went through the turf, then met packed soil. He tried closer to the cut. The branch sank to its full length.

"The road stone is holding," Hedd said, "but the bank beside it isn't. We'll clear the water first. No one puts weight on that edge."

Philip liked having someone else decide where not to stand. He had been doing too much of that alone.

"This is the break," Hedd said. "The road office marked it impassable twenty years ago."

"Could it be cleared?" Philip asked.

"For carts, perhaps. For a giant, I don't know."

Filroy walked along the upper edge of the cut, sniffing at the ground. He stopped at a narrow strip of exposed basalt. "The dry rise continues there. It goes east, then bends toward a hollow."

"You've been there?" Philip asked.

"I have been on the rise. I have not been in your hollow."

Hedd unrolled his survey sheet. The dotted road ended at the drainage cut. "The old map shows a turn on the far side, but the landowner built a fence over it."

Philip looked at the wooden barrier. It had been made to keep sheep from wandering into the gardens. Its posts were wedged between the old stones, not sunk into the earth. He tried one. It shifted.

"This could move," he said.

"Not by one person," Hedd replied.

"I know."

They examined the old stones beyond the fence. One had a shallow iron groove along its top. Philip recognized the cut

from the marker at the causeway. It was not a route marker, exactly, but a guide for a gate or movable barrier. The iron had rusted away, leaving the groove filled with soil.

"The turn is under here," he said.

Hedd knelt beside him. They cleared moss and dirt with the edge of the shovel. A line of fitted stone emerged, curving east beneath the bramble.

Aro looked toward the city wall. "If the giant is following the ridge, this is where it would have turned."

"If the way is open," Philip said.

Hedd probed the drainage cut with his shovel. The blade struck stone. He cleared away a branch and pulled out a mat of roots. Water began to drain through the gap, slow but steady.

"We can open this enough for people to cross," he said. "The road needs a crew. We need to move the barrier and test the far side. It may still be blocked."

Hedd paced the far edge and looked through the bramble. A line of old stone showed beneath the roots, then disappeared into a thicket. The lane beyond was too narrow for a cart in its present state.

"It'll take hours to clear this," he said. "More if the far side has another washout."

"The giant may arrive before then," Aro said.

"Then we clear what we can and move people first," Hedd replied. "A road that is half open is still a road for walking away from."

Philip looked at the track marks near the barrier. The giant had stepped close enough to press a deep print into the damp earth. From the print, a smaller line of disturbed soil turned toward the east rise. It could be the creature's attempt to find a way around the fence. It could be an ordinary change of footing. Philip refused to call it proof.

"We should mark the place it turned," he said. "If it comes back, we can see whether it chooses the same ground."

Hedd pulled a strip of survey cloth from his pack and tied it to a branch beyond the print. "There. If we need to compare, we can find it again."

"Can a giant cross?" Aro asked.

"I don't know."

Philip looked at the footprints in the soft earth. One deep print angled toward the barrier. Another had turned along the slope, where the ground rose toward the east. The giant had not gone through. The path had been closed.

"We can't promise it will take the route," Philip said. "But we can make the route possible."

Hedd nodded. "That I can report."

They returned to the road office with the survey sheet marked, a strip of fitted stone exposed, and mud on their clothes. The roadwarden listened while Hedd explained the drainage cut and the movable barrier. She asked Aro to describe the giant's direction, then asked Philip to repeat exactly what the wayknife had shown.

He did not call it a map. He did not say the giant was searching for shelter. He said what he had seen and what he believed the evidence might mean.

The roadwarden studied the marked sheet. "I can authorize a small crew to clear the barrier and open the drainage. We will move the outer farms away from the road. The city keeps the wall prepared until the giant turns."

She asked Hedd how many people he needed. He named four for the drainage, two for the barrier, and one to watch the ridge. The roadwarden took a pencil and changed the number twice. Every worker sent to the road was someone not carrying water, moving carts, or guarding a gate. She did not make the arithmetic look easier than it was.

"We clear the drainage first," she said. "If the water rises, we stop. The farms nearest the lane move inside the wall. No one goes beyond the marked line without a guard."

"And the giant?" Aro asked.

"We watch it. If it reaches the wall, we act."

"That's reasonable," Philip said.

"It is expensive," the roadwarden replied. "Reasonable decisions often are."

Father waited in the infirmary when Philip returned. He had been carried back to bed and had slept. His face was pale, his eyes tired.

"They found the turn?" he asked.

"Part of it. The crew can clear it. We don't know if the giant will take it."

Father's gaze dropped to the dagger at Philip's belt. "Then you should stay here."

Philip felt the old argument rising between them. Father had said it softly. It still sounded like an order.

"We'll talk after you've rested," Philip said.

"Philip—"

"After you've rested."

He turned away before either of them could make the next sentence worse.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

What Strength Costs

Father was awake when Philip returned to the infirmary.

The healer had left a bowl of broth on the stool beside his bed. Father had eaten half of it. He was trying to sit up, though the splint and the bandage around his ribs made the effort slow.

"The roadwarden has given us a crew," Philip said. "They're clearing the barrier and the drainage cut."

"And the giant?"

"Still moving toward the outer farms."

Father looked at the dagger on Philip's belt. "Give me the knife."

Philip stayed where he was. "Why?"

"You're not going back out."

"The roadwarden asked me to help guide the crew."

"You have a head wound and a hand that can barely close."

"I can point at a map."

"You can fall over. You nearly did twice on the road."

"I did fall over once."

"That is not an argument in your favor."

Father reached for the knife. Philip stepped back. The movement pulled at Father's leg and pain caught his face. He stopped, breathing through his teeth.

The healer was at the other end of the ward. Other patients turned toward the sound, then tried not to look. People in infirmaries had many ways of pretending not to hear a family argument. The most common was to make a great show of examining the ceiling.

"You said you would share what you knew," Philip said.

"I am sharing this: you are hurt, and the giant is dangerous."

"You knew the giant was moving before we left Hazelwood."

"I did not know it was this close."

"You knew there was a danger. You didn't tell me. You told me to fight bullies, but when I have something useful to say about a road, you want me sent away."

Father's hand lowered to the blanket. "This is different."

"How?"

"You could be killed."

"So could the people outside the wall."

"That is why the guards are there."

"And the roadworker? And Aro? And the people clearing the turn?"

Father did not answer.

Philip's voice shook. He hated that it did. "You keep telling me to be brave in the way you understand. When I do something else, you call it a risk."

"You are fifteen."

"I was fifteen when you decided to bring me past the Shelf Road without telling me what you knew."

The words seemed to stop Father more completely than the pain had. His face changed. Not much, but enough for Philip to see that the argument had reached the place both of them had been avoiding.

"I thought I could keep you safe," Father said.

"By choosing for me."

"By keeping you out of the old life."

"You don't get to keep me out of something by hiding it from me."

Father looked toward the window. Beyond it, the city's east wall cut a pale line across the sky. "Your mother died while I was away."

"You told me."

"I thought if I brought the Slayer work into our house, it would take you away too. I thought the safest thing was to leave the past where it was."

"But it wasn't where it was. It was on the road with us."

Father closed his eyes. "I know."

"You can't make me safe by making every choice before I know there's a choice."

"I was afraid."

The admission came quietly. It was not an excuse. Father looked at the blanket as if the words had cost him more than the journey had.

"I was afraid I would lose you as I lost her," he said. "I thought if you learned to fight, you would be harder to hurt. I thought if you never learned about the Slayers, you would never want their life. I told myself those things could fit together."

"They don't."

"No."

Philip touched the dagger's hilt. "This was a gift. You gave it to me because you wanted me to have a choice. You can't give it back to yourself when I make one."

Father looked up. His hand moved toward the knife again, then stopped on the blanket. "You're right."

"I'm going with the crew. I'll stay behind the workers. I'll tell them what I saw, and I'll stop if I can't stand."

Father's jaw tightened. He looked as if he wanted to forbid it. Then his shoulders sank a little.

"I don't like it."

"I know."

"I'm still afraid."

"I know that too."

Father drew a slow breath. "Then go. Tell me what you learn when you return."

Philip had expected to feel relief. Instead, the permission sat between them like a narrow plank laid across a gap. Father had not told him to go away; he had also not said he trusted

the plan. Philip could not demand that the fear vanish before he moved.

"I'll come back," Philip said.

"I know."

Father's gaze stayed on the knife. "I should have told you about the road before we left. I should have told you what Aro saw."

"Yes."

"I'm not asking you to stop being angry."

"Good."

The healer arrived with a cup of water and a strip of clean cloth. She inspected Philip's scalp and asked him to follow her finger with his eyes. He did, though the finger seemed to leave a faint trail after it stopped.

"You are not going near the front line," she said. "You are not reading that knife again unless somebody with a steadier head is there to catch you."

"I can stay behind the workers."

"You can stay behind the workers and drink the water."

Philip took the cup. The water tasted clean. He drank slowly, then gave the cup back when she told him to stop. Father watched without trying to take it from him.

Philip nodded. He had not forgiven Father. Father had not become unafraid. But the knife remained at Philip's belt, and Father had let him keep it.

The warning bell sounded from the east wall.

Once. Then twice.

Philip finished the water. The healer checked the bandage once more, then let him go.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

Broken Stones

The east service road filled with workers before the afternoon was over.

They came from the gatehouse, the farms, and the road office. Some carried shovels. Others brought pry bars, ropes, and a handcart loaded with tools. The roadwarden had sent a small crew, but the warning bells had persuaded several more people to join them. It is difficult to keep a crew small when everyone can hear the reason for the work.

The crew did not agree on what the work was for. One farmer thought they were building a barricade. A gate guard thought they were clearing a retreat path. Hedd told them they were opening an old road and would decide how to use it when they had seen what lay beyond it.

"That sounds like a good way to get halfway through two jobs," the farmer said.

"It is," Hedd replied. "So we will start with the ditch."

Philip helped carry the lighter tools, though the healer had made him promise not to lift anything heavy. A woman with a red scarf took the pry bar from him and handed him a coil of marking cord instead. He started to object, then noticed his fingers had begun to tremble around the rope. He thanked her and carried the cord.

Hedd directed the clearing at the drainage cut. Philip stayed behind the first line of workers as promised. Aro watched the ridge with his bow unstrung. Filroy moved along the edge of the old lane, then returned to the basalt rise.

One of the farmers whose land touched the old lane stood by the gate, refusing to leave his cart. He had loaded it with

sacks and a wooden chest. The cart's wheel had sunk into the soft shoulder, and he was trying to free it by pulling the horse sideways.

"The roadwarden said to move inside," Hedd called.

"I'm not leaving my tools out here."

"You can bring the cart through the service gate."

"The wheel is stuck."

Philip looked at the ground. The wheel had sunk into the edge of the drainage ditch. The horse was pulling at an angle, making the rut deeper. He walked over, staying inside the marked cord.

"Can you unhitch the horse?" he asked.

The farmer looked at him. "What would that do?"

"It would stop the cart from pulling deeper while we lift the wheel."

The farmer hesitated, then let the reins go. Hedd and two workers levered the axle while Philip pushed a flat stone beneath the wheel. It rose out of the rut. The horse was led through the gate, then the cart followed.

The farmer picked up his tools and went inside without thanking anyone. He had remembered the sack of seed on the cart and was counting it under his breath. Philip understood. Some people used thanks when they had something left to spare.

"The dry ground continues," he said. "The thorns are thick, but the stones are under them."

Hedd and two workers levered the wooden barrier out of its brackets. It scraped free and toppled onto the grass. They dragged it aside, then cleared the loose branches from the ditch. Water trickled through the opened gap. The old stones held.

The flow increased as the blockage loosened. Silt poured out in a brown ribbon. One of the workers stepped too close and the turf slumped beneath his boot. Hedd caught the back of his coat and pulled him away. They drove a stake into firm ground and tied the marking cord across the soft edge.

Philip watched the little stream cut through the mud. “If it keeps draining, the bank might hold.”

“Might,” Hedd said. “We’ll put a cart over it before we ask a giant.”

The water carried out a branch and a strip of rotten fence. Hedd set a second worker to clear the far side while the first kept watch on the bank. They used a rope to move the heavier stones, lifting one at a time and testing each place before putting weight on it. The work went slowly. Whenever someone suggested moving faster, Hedd asked which part of the ditch they wanted to collapse.

No one answered.

“The map says the turn is farther west,” Hedd called.

Philip compared the dotted line with the exposed stonework. “The map is off. The road bends here, along the ridge.”

“You’re sure?”

“No. The tracks and the ground say it does. The marker said there was an older line east, but it was faint.”

Hedd looked at the map, then at the ridge. He scratched out the old line and drew a new one. “I’ll mark it as observed, not confirmed.”

“That’s fair.”

The roadwarden arrived with two gate guards. She checked the cleared ditch, examined the stone turn, and spoke with Hedd. Then she looked to Philip.

“Can the wayknife confirm the route here?”

“There’s a marker at the sound post. I could try it, but my head is still moving from the last reading.”

The roadwarden looked from the marker to the open turn. “Do we need another reading to clear the road?”

Philip studied the tracks in the soft bank and the fitted stones under the grass. “The causeway trace ran east. The ground and the prints show the turn. We can clear it far enough to test the road without pretending we know where it ends.”

"Then we'll mark it as a working route," she said. "No one calls it confirmed until the far side is inspected."

Philip let the wayknife stay sheathed. He could feel the urge to ask it again, to turn a direction into an answer. The dizziness had not passed, and the marker could not tell them whether the giant would choose the road. The stones and tracks were the evidence they had.

The roadwarden wrote the observation on the survey sheet. She did not ask Philip to read again.

Father had been brought to the outer gate on a handcart, against the healer's better judgment and with a guard assigned to watch him. He could not stand. His leg was bound in the proper splint, and the cot was secured to the cart. He called out from the shelter of the gatehouse.

"The causeway should meet the east farm lane beyond the second well!"

Hedd checked the map. "There are three wells."

"The one with the stone trough," Father said. "It was there when I last walked the route."

"That narrows it down," Philip said.

Father gave him a tired look. "It was a memorable trough."

"I'm sure."

The roadwarden sent a pair of workers to check the lane. The rest continued clearing the stones. They uncovered a broad stretch of the old turn and enough of the drainage channel to let water escape. A farm cart crossed the cut without sinking. No one called that proof a giant could cross, but it was the first useful test.

The cart's wheels left two shallow ruts on the far bank. The roadwarden had the crew mark them and measure the depth. Hedd checked the axle clearance and the stones under the water. The cut had passed one ordinary test. The giant would weigh far more than a cart, but the test told them where the ground held and where it did not.

"We should put another stone here," Philip said, pointing to the softer edge.

Hedd shook his head. “A loose stone will roll under a heavy foot. We need a broad bed, or the weight goes into the bank.”

They fetched a slab from the broken barrier and laid it across the shallowest part. Hedd tested it with a pry bar. It shifted by less than a finger’s width. He marked that too.

A bell rang from the wall.

The giant had reached the outer approach.

Aro strung his bow. He moved to a position where he could see through a gap in the trees. His face settled into the expression Philip remembered from the shop, when Aro had talked about the Alcrog. Only now Philip knew that confidence and grief could wear the same coat.

“Hold the road clear,” the roadwarden told the workers. “Move everyone back from the approach. No one fires unless it reaches the wall.”

Aro raised his bow.

The giant emerged beyond the fields.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

The Long Road Around

The giant came to the outer farms at dusk.

The field walls reached no higher than its knees. It moved between them slowly, stepping over a collapsed section and turning aside from a cart abandoned near the road. Behind it, dust and rain lifted from the ground with each footfall.

The defenders formed a line near the east wall. They carried spears, crossbows, and two heavy bows mounted on frames. None of the weapons made the line look large. The roadwarden stood behind it with the gate captain and a map rolled beneath her arm.

The giant stopped where the river road met the old farm lane. Its head turned toward the city wall. The gate captain raised one hand. Aro drew his bow.

The defenders did not move as one. A crossbowman lifted his weapon too soon and had to lower it when the captain signaled. One of the heavy bows creaked as its crew shifted the frame. On the road behind them, people pushed carts toward the inner gate. A wheel struck a stone and lodged. Two guards left the line to free it, then ran back before the giant took another step.

The roadwarden repeated the evacuation order. Her voice carried only as far as the first row of workers. The gate captain sent a runner to the inner road. No one shouted at the giant. No one wanted to be the sound it turned toward.

Philip watched the evacuation line move. A cart had been turned sideways in the gate and blocked the passage. Two guards lifted one end while the owner pulled at the reins. The

horse resisted, then stepped forward when a child came to its head with a handful of oats.

"Keep moving," the gate captain called. "Leave what you can't carry."

One woman looked back toward the fields. Her house stood nearest the outer wall. She had locked it before leaving, though the lock would not matter to a giant. Philip wanted to tell her that the city could rebuild a house, but it would have sounded like a promise he had no right to make.

He moved closer to Hedd. "Are the workers clear?"

"Almost."

"They need to be clear now."

Hedd signaled again. The last two workers left the lane and moved behind the stone wall. The road stood open between the giant and the ridge.

Philip stood beside the cleared causeway, far enough from the front that Hedd could pull him back if the ground shifted. His head still hurt from the reading. The wayknife hung at his belt, heavy against his hip.

"It's looking at the wall," someone said.

"It's looking past the wall," Philip answered.

The giant turned its shoulders. Its gaze followed the line of the basalt rise. It took one step toward the wall, then another toward the eastern lane. The old route lay open but narrow, half-hidden by brush and the broken farm barrier.

"It keeps angling east," Philip said. "It went around the wet hollow. It turned at the causeway. It's looking for the high ground."

"Or the city," Aro said. His arrow remained aimed at the giant's upper chest. "If it comes closer, I will shoot."

Philip looked at the roadwarden. "We need the old turn open all the way. The barrier is down, but there are branches beyond the cut. It may not see the path."

"The workers are there," she said.

"They need to move farther back."

Hedd signaled to the crew. They retreated behind the drainage cut, leaving only the marked lane open. One worker stumbled over the barrier and dropped a pry bar. The clatter rang across the field.

The giant turned toward it.

The worker froze. Philip saw the giant's hand lift. Aro's bow drew tighter. Then the giant's gaze moved from the fallen tool to the open strip of basalt beyond it. Its hand lowered. It stepped around the worker's position, not toward him, and the roadwarden's guards pulled the man back by his coat.

"Clear the lane," Philip called. "No loose tools. No one behind it."

The roadwarden repeated the instruction. Two workers gathered the tools and moved behind the stone wall.

The giant shifted its weight. A low wall collapsed beneath its foot, sending stones into the lane. One struck the drainage slab and bounced toward the workers. Hedd pulled Philip behind the post. The stone hit the road where Philip had been standing and broke in two.

"Clear," Philip said, though the workers were already behind cover.

The giant did not look toward him. It was watching the slope beyond the wall. Its hand pressed briefly against the earth again, testing the ground. The gesture was slow and uncertain, not a threat, though Philip knew it could become one if the path failed.

Father's handcart stood inside the gatehouse. He had insisted on being carried to the wall, though he could not see much from where he lay. The guards had kept him behind the stone post. He did not call Philip away.

The roadwarden gave a signal. Two crews moved to the old lane and pulled the last branches clear. Another group opened the service gate wider. The gate captain ordered families from the nearest farms toward the inner road.

The giant stepped forward. A farm wall cracked beneath its heel.

Aro's bow creaked.

"The marker," Philip said. "There's one at the sound post. I can check the direction once, then we open the turn."

"You're still dizzy," Hedd said. "I'm here to steady you if you need it."

Father's voice carried from the gatehouse. "Philip, you don't have to—"

He stopped. The order did not come.

Philip went to the sound post, a short iron-capped stone beside the old road. He knelt, set one hand against the ground, and brought the knife close. The hilt warmed. The trace pulled east, faint beneath the heavy rhythm of the giant's steps. It was a direction, no more than that. It did not say the hollow was safe. It did not say the giant would follow.

Philip pulled the knife away.

The road leaned sideways. His stomach rolled. He caught the post and stayed still until the stones stopped shifting under him.

His fingers had gone numb around the hilt. He slipped the knife back into its sheath and pressed both palms to the marker. The metal was cool now. The ground beneath it did not move. He focused on that until his balance returned enough for him to speak.

"East," he said. "The old line is there. Open the full turn. Keep the workers back."

The roadwarden repeated the instruction. The crew dragged the last barrier aside and cleared the lane. Filroy stood at the far end, beyond the workers, on the dry rise. He did not call or beckon. He simply moved along the stones, staying clear of the giant's path.

The giant stepped over the broken wall and faced the city again.

The defenders held. The heavy bows remained aimed, though no one released. Aro's arrow tracked the giant's shoulder as it turned. Philip could see the line of the shaft against the gray sky, thin as a pencil mark. The gate captain

raised a hand to stop the archers from loosing. The giant's next step landed beside the old farm lane, crushing a low wall but leaving the open stones clear.

Aro's bow was still drawn. Philip saw his hands tighten on the grip. The old story stood between them: the swallowed friend, the heart cut free, the body that had not survived the victory.

"It has not attacked us," Philip said.

"It has broken the farms."

"It's not trying to reach us."

"You cannot know that."

"No. But we can see where it keeps choosing to go."

The giant's head turned. Its attention shifted from the wall to the open lane. It lowered one hand and pressed the ground ahead of it. The fingers spread against the stone. It tested the route, then rose.

Aro's arrow remained drawn for one more breath.

Then he lowered the bow.

"Open the gate," he said.

The roadwarden ordered the service gate and the old turn kept clear. The defenders stepped back from the lane, leaving space. The giant moved forward. It stopped at the drainage cut, where water still ran through the stones. It placed one foot on the near bank, tested the firmness, and crossed.

The old road held.

The giant paused halfway across. Its foot had sunk into the wet edge, and the drainage stones shifted under its weight. Philip heard the crew suck in breath together. The giant lifted its foot, set it farther onto the broad slab, and tested again. The stone settled but did not break.

Only when it had transferred its weight did the people behind the wall begin to breathe normally.

The giant followed the basalt rise east. It did not hurry. It did not look back at the city. The crew kept far behind, clearing fallen branches only after it had passed. Aro walked

with his bow unstrung. Father's handcart followed at a distance, guarded by two soldiers.

Philip's head still swam. Hedd offered an arm. Philip took it.

They were not leading the giant. They were making a road available and keeping people away from its feet. The difference was not large enough to make anyone safe, but it was large enough to give the giant a choice.

Ahead, the old causeway curved into the trees.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

The Hollow Beyond

Stillstone Hollow opened beneath the eastern ridge.

The basalt walls formed a shallow bowl ringed by old pines. Water ran down the rock in narrow threads, but the ground at the center was dry. A shelf of stone overhung one side, deep enough to shelter the giant from the rain.

The giant entered without ceremony. It stood in the center of the hollow and lowered itself onto the stone. The earth trembled once as its weight settled. Then it became still.

The people who had followed at a distance stopped among the trees. No one approached. No one called to it. The giant's head rested against the rock, its arms folded near its chest. It did not seem peaceful. It seemed exhausted.

One scout began to move down the ridge. The roadwarden caught his sleeve and pointed to the giant's hand. Its fingers had shifted against the stone. The scout stopped. After a moment the giant drew one slow breath, lifted its head, and pressed its shoulder against the overhang. Small pieces of grit fell from the basalt.

Everyone moved back another dozen paces.

The giant settled again. The hollow held. That was the only conclusion the watchers were willing to make.

The roadwarden sent two scouts to watch from the ridge and ordered the clearing crew to mark the route for future repair. The city would keep the outer road open and post a warning at the old turn. The giant had reached shelter. The road would still need tending after it was gone, or after it moved on.

She posted guards on the road, not at the hollow's entrance. Their orders were to keep travelers away and send word if the giant moved. Aro agreed to stay until the first watch changed. He was not asked to shoot, and he did not ask for permission to approach.

Aro stood beside Philip, his bow slung over his shoulder.

"You were right to make us wait," he said.

"We didn't know enough."

"We still don't know everything."

"No."

Aro looked toward the hollow. "My friend would have wanted me to tell his story honestly."

"You did."

"Not the whole of it." Aro's voice lowered. "I told people what he did. I left out how long he was afraid before he went in. I left out that I told him not to. I made the ending sound like proof that courage was enough."

Philip thought of the man inside the Alcrog, and of the hunter who had watched him die after the beast fell. "It was courage."

"Yes. It was also a choice with a cost."

Philip nodded. That was the part a story could keep and still make room for the person who had lived it.

Filroy stood at the edge of the trees. He watched the hollow, then the road leading back toward Malcore. His den lay somewhere beyond the forest, damaged or not. He had not said whether he would go back to it. Foxes were not known for announcing their schedules.

"You're leaving," Philip said.

"I am going home."

"Will you come to Malcore?"

"No."

"Will I see you again?"

Filroy looked at him. "You will be in a forest again someday."

"That doesn't answer me."

"It is the answer I have."

Philip held out the last piece of bread from Aro's pack. Filroy sniffed it and turned away.

"You can keep it," Philip said.

"I can find food."

"I know."

Filroy trotted between the trees, paused once to look back, then disappeared into the brush.

Father was taken to the infirmary again. The healer said his leg would need weeks to mend and his head required continued watching. He would not ride home for some time. The city had spare rooms for travelers whose families were being treated, and Philip slept in one of them with clean sheets and a bowl of broth.

The first night, he woke whenever a bell rang. The city had many bells, and each one seemed to mean the giant had moved again. A nurse came in after the third time and showed him the watch board outside the ward. The marks beside the eastern post had not changed. The giant was still in the hollow.

Philip slept better after that, though not well. At dawn he woke with his hand clenched around the edge of the blanket. The fingers were stiff, but they opened. The healer said the bruising would take time and the cut at his scalp was clean. She gave him bread and broth before she let him visit Father.

Father had spent most of the night asleep. The healer had set his lower leg and secured it with a firm splint. She repeated that he would need weeks, not days, and that he was not to walk on it. Father looked at the splint as if it had insulted him personally.

"It has a point," Philip said.

"What point?"

"It's keeping you in bed."

"Then it's a poor argument."

The roadwarden came to see them the next morning. She brought the survey sheet and asked Father to mark the old causeway from memory. Father corrected two turns and

admitted he was uncertain about a third. Philip added the visible track and the marker readings in a different color. The two lines did not perfectly overlap. The roadwarden kept both.

"We'll send a crew to maintain the old turn," she said. "If the giant leaves the hollow, we'll need to know whether it uses the road again."

"And if it doesn't?" Philip asked.

"Then we will have repaired a road people can use."

The roadwarden rolled the survey sheet and tucked it under her arm. "This road was allowed to disappear because it stopped being useful to the people who kept the records. We can at least make sure the next person knows where it goes."

Philip watched her return to the gatehouse. Outside the wall, carts waited to go home or to find a different road. The city was not finished being frightened, but it had begun to make a list of what needed repairing.

Over the next days, Father woke more often. They spoke in pieces. Some conversations ended in silence; others ended because Father needed sleep. He told Philip about the Slayers' routes, about roads used to evacuate villages, and about times the same roads had been used to lead beasts toward a trap. Philip asked questions. Father answered what he could and admitted when he did not remember.

He apologized on the third morning.

"I told you fighting was the only way to be strong," Father said. "Then I kept the truth from you because I thought I could protect you by choosing what you knew. I was wrong."

Philip looked at the bandage on Father's head. "I'm still angry."

"You should be."

"I don't want to join the Slayers."

"There are no Slayers to join."

"You know what I mean."

Father nodded. "Then you won't."

"I want to learn how to read the roads. And I want to learn enough to get away if someone corners me again."

"I can teach you both."

"When your leg works."

"That may take a while."

"The shop can wait."

Father's eyes moved to him. "You still want the shop?"

"Yes."

"Good." Father gave a small, tired smile. "It is a fine place to learn how much people will pay for a sack of flour."

"They usually pay the marked price."

"That is what they tell you."

Philip laughed. It surprised him. The laugh hurt his ribs, though not enough to stop it.

Weeks later, when Father could sit in a cart without the healer objecting, Philip stood beyond Malcore's gate and looked north. The road wound away between farms and low ridges. It would lead to the river, to the forest, and eventually to Hazelwood.

By then, Aro had gone back to the Road Office with a report of his own. He had left the Alcrog hide behind for a day while it dried, then put it on again. Philip had asked whether he would keep telling the story of his friend.

"Yes," Aro had said. "But I'll tell the part where he was afraid. And the part where I was."

Philip had not told him that this was better. Aro knew.

The wayknife rested in its box at his side. It did not point home. It did not choose for him.

Philip knew the road would take time, and that time would include sore hands, bad weather, and probably at least one argument about how much flour to buy. He also knew he would travel it when Father was ready.

The first journey beyond Hazelwood had not made him a warrior. It had taught him that being afraid did not take a choice away, and that the best road was often the one people made possible together.

He turned back toward the gate. Father waited inside, leaning on a cane, impatient with the healer and trying not to show it.

"Are you coming?" Father called.

"I'm looking."

"At what?"

Philip glanced once more at the road.

"Where it goes."